

BLADES IN THE DARK

DEEP CUTS



A SETTING & SYSTEMS EXPANSION

FORGED IN THE DARK

JOHN HARPER

BLADES IN THE DARK

**DEEP
CUTS**

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PART ONE
SETTING

INNOVATIONS

NEW STANDARD ITEMS

Arclighter: A pen-sized gadget powered by a vial of electropasm inserted into it. When the mechanism is activated with a flick of the thumb, it produces a small arc of crackling energy—useful for lighting a cigarette, seeing in the dark, or powering an electric device (until the electropasm runs out). A wide variety of styles exist, from cheap, disposable units to finely engraved luxury items. [O LOAD]

Glimmer: The colloquial name for a faceted crystalline attachment for an arclighter, which turns it into a small lamp, easily clipped to a lapel or belt to provide hands-free light when you need it. [O LOAD]

Percussion Slug Gun: Commonly known as a “slugger,” a break-action firearm with a short, wide barrel. It operates by discharging a *percussion slug*—a plasm-charged shell that fires a thunderous concussive blast instead of a projectile. The slug was originally designed for rock breaking in mining work, but after homemade “sluggers” started appearing on the streets, several firearm manufacturers—including Booker Arms, Blackburn, and Hellyers Industrial—have started to produce them (as well as converter kits for traditional guns).

Sluggers are favored by underworld thugs for their intimidating appearance as well as their less-lethal effect—producing a heavy concussive impact (enough to break bone at close range) rather than penetrating the body and risking a kill shot.

Slugger pistols have limited range (10 paces) and even long rifle versions lack effectiveness beyond 30 paces.

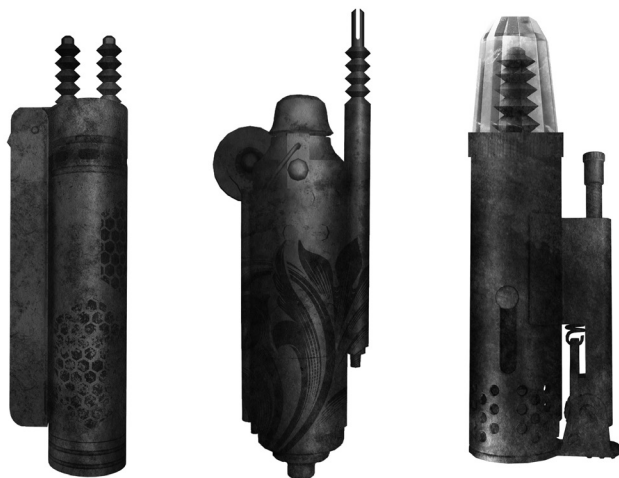
[PISTOL: 1 LOAD / RIFLE: 2 LOAD]

“The Prichard” Plasmographic Camera: The latest innovation of the Prichard company, this handheld device focuses light onto thin metal plates treated with quicksilver to produce photographs (once they’re developed by a specially trained photo-lab technician).

The mechanism sometimes captures energies in the nearby ghost field, resulting in unusual artifacts in the images. [1 LOAD]

ARCLIGHTERS

GLIMMER



A “SLUGGER” PISTOL

PERCUSSION SLUG



Unity Era Calendar and Unification Map: New calendars and maps have been issued to citizens across the Imperium. The Emperor has decreed a new era—the era of **Unity**. Rather than chronicling the time since the cataclysm, the calendars have been reset—counting the years since the Unity War ended and the Imperium became whole. So far, the new system is only regularly used on official imperial documents—the general citizenry hasn’t bothered to adapt to the new dates in their daily lives.

As a sign of celebration (or a propaganda move, according to some), the months of the year have been renamed to commemorate the six Imperial Territories. Each month is named for the territorial symbol chosen for that region. Regional citizens were not consulted. [o LOAD]

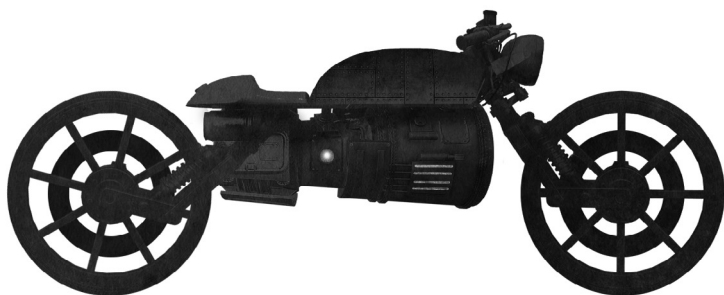
UNITY ERA CALENDAR MONTHS

- **Brightsky:** Named for the profusion of electric lights in the Imperial City of Akoros, which transform eternal night into eternal day—especially during the elaborate fireworks celebrations for the new year.
- **Emberspring:** Named for the Akorosi legend that says a piece of the broken sun rests beneath the waves of the Dagger Isles, providing the nurturing warmth and heat to grow the jungles of that region.
- **Crucible:** Named for the “indomitable spirit” of the Skovlan people. Thousands of Unity War refugees still suffer and struggle to find a place in Doskvol among people who consider them traitors.
- **Tribute:** Named for the legend that the gargantuan stone towers that make up Tycheros were formed when the ancients created the world, as a monument to their glory.
- **Bastion:** Named for the fabled bastions of Severos, the only remaining citadels of the pre-cataclysm, whose power still protects the Severosi. Unity propaganda claims the power flows from the arcane might of the Emperor. Scholars who disagree have become hard to find.
- **Starfall:** Named for the “fallen stars” of the Iruvian capitol of U’Duasha—crystalline pillars that fell to earth, said to contain an arcane power that allowed Iruvia to thrive despite the cataclysm. On the Unification Map, the pillars are toppled beneath an unbroken sun—the symbol of the Immortal Emperor. Rumor is, all the Unity calendars and maps sent to Iruvia were burned.



U N I T Y

BOLTON AUTOCYCLE



NEW RARE TECHNOLOGY

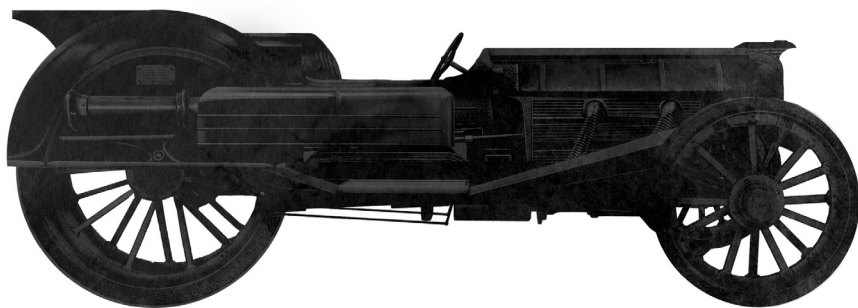
Bolton Autocycle: With the recent invention of a stable plasmic turbine engine, it was inevitable that some daredevil would attach wheels to one. The Bolton Autocycle is now the fastest thing on the streets, and the most deadly to its pilots. Only seven have ever been built—three of which were destroyed in explosive crashes, while a fourth lost control and slid into a canal in Crow's Foot.

Lightning Thrower: An experimental tool and weapon developed by the Spirit Wardens and Sparkwrights, consisting of a belt-pouch battery pack, cable, and handheld rod that projects a continuous whip-like bolt of lightning when triggered. It's designed to repel or restrain spirits, but is very effective against living targets as well. The belt-mounted battery provides only a minute of continuous use, but the extreme heat generated usually melts the projector prongs before then. [1 LOAD]

Monitor Sphere: A spark-craft orb containing a demi-sensorium and attuned spirit essence. The orb can see and hear its surroundings and may be questioned about activities it has observed, as well as follow simple instructions, such as raising an alarm when a condition is met. With a special attachment, it can produce detailed drawings of events and faces from its memory. If a **spectrovox radio** antenna is attached (see **page 11**), the attuned essence may be held at a remote location, receiving the surveillance memories via aetheric waves. [2 LOAD]

Sparkrunner Rig: A full-body harness, plasmic battery, metal-clad boots, and connected goggles, which allows the operator to strongly interact with electropasmic structures in the ghost field to apparently “run on air” by leaping and skating on invisible spectral surfaces as if they were solid (for more details, see **page 26**). [2 LOAD]

HOCKNEY 3-WHEEL STEAM CAR



Hockney Steam Car: A steam-driven automobile (sedan or truck), powered by electric boilers—named for their inventor and manufacturer, the Hockney Conveyance Company. These vehicles are not yet mass-produced and cost 20 coin (or more), so they haven't yet entered widespread usage among the public. Private purchase of a Hockney must be done by special order, often taking months to fulfill.

Some city institutions, such as the Brigade, Cabbies, and Bluecoats, have begun to add a few Hockneys into their fleets as budgets allow, but their constant need for maintenance and specially refined fuel leads some to believe they're more trouble than they're worth.

NEW RESTRICTED TECHNOLOGY

Spectrovox Radio: An innovative form of radio-wave technology developed by Dunvil Industries, initially for Imperial Navy ships at sea, but now used in a variety of applications. Broadcast and receiving units are very bulky and rare, with only a handful in private ownership.

In Doskvol, large broadcast towers equipped with searchlights and **monitor spheres** (page 10) have appeared across the city, recording surveillance and blaring Imperial propaganda messages promoting the strength of Unity. They are very unpopular.

This technology interacts strangely with the ghost field, sometimes receiving signals from the past (or the future?) as well as nearby spirits and echoes. Deathseeker crows become disoriented when they pass by a radio tower—the Spirit Wardens are not happy about their proliferation across the city. [NOT PORTABLE]

HELLYERS REPEATING COILGUN



Hellyers Repeating Coilgun: This heavy machine gun is the newest in advanced Imperial military technology (which is still heavily researched despite the Imperium's claim that all wars have been won). It harnesses electroplasmic energy to power an accelerator coil to launch explosive projectiles at a high rate of continuous fire. Requires the use of triple-refined electroplasm (known as "white fire") to operate, which is highly volatile and dangerous to handle.

Only a few coilguns have been issued to military units outside the Imperial City and the Navy, including two that Captain Vale acquired for testing at the City Watch proving range near Ironhook Prison. [9 LOAD]

Imperial Airships: As the era of Unity dawns across the Imperium, the Immortal Emperor expands his reach, building new vessels of war to send to every far-flung corner of the Shattered Isles. The Imperial Airship fleet, which had consisted only of the prototype vessels *SOVEREIGN* and *DOMINION*, has grown to a force of 16 warships and escorts, thanks to a massive design and construction project accomplished at the Cloudspire aeronautics facility.

Each titanic metal-hulled airship is equipped with sweeping red searchlights and dozens of coilguns, as well as a leviathan-class lightning projector and barrier to deal with any horrors during flights over the deathlands. See **page 14** for more details on the airship currently stationed in the skies of Doskvol.

FACTIONS

SECRETS AHEAD

If you're a player who wants to discover the secret aspects of these factions in play, don't read the situations marked with ♦.

THE BRIGADE	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The firefighters of the city. Loved for their heroics or hated for their looting.</i>	Win back public trust after the Coalridge incident	12

TURF: Fire stations in every district and a dock for harbor patrol boats.

NPCs: **Chief Pickett** (leader, *disciplined, hardened, judgmental*).

Captain Marsh (veteran crew captain, *conflicted, experienced*).

ASSETS: A fleet of steam-powered firetrucks and harbor patrol boats. Hidden caches of valuables and coin looted during fire calls.

QUIRKS: Also known as "Sallies" (from salamanders, an ancient name).

ALLIES: City Council.

ENEMIES: Coalridge citizens, Skovlander Refugees.

SITUATION: As part of the City Council's efforts to suppress the pro-union movement, the Brigade was ordered to let a building in Coalridge burn down. A dozen people died, and the Brigade is now targeted for violence by Coalridge citizens and pro-union supporters.

CABBIES	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The guild of public coach drivers.</i>	Modernize the guild	8

TURF: A maintenance facility and goat stables in Coalridge (HQ).

NPCs: **Ellis Lockwood** (co-chief, *pragmatic, tough, visionary*).

Hazel Chord (co-chief, *wise, patient, charming*).

ASSETS: A fleet of goat-drawn coaches. Goat stables and breeding pens. Records of pick-ups and drop-offs. City-wide gossip network.

ALLIES: City Council, The Red Sashes, The Wraiths.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats, The Lampblacks.

SITUATION: Chord and Lockwood both want to modernize the cabbies, incorporating newer steam-powered vehicles into the fleet, but most cabbies are resistant to the idea, preferring traditional ways.

COVENANT	TIER VI	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A massive Imperial airship that now hovers in the sky of Doskvol.</i>	Find a way to rescue the airship <i>VERDICT</i>	12

TURF: The sky over Doskvol and the surrounding region. The refueling and maintenance dock newly constructed atop the Lord Governor's stronghold. Commandeered offices and storerooms in the stronghold.

NPCs: **Admiral Bowmore** (commanding officer, *valiant, sharp, inspiring*). **Commander Farros** (second officer, *daring, loyal, tactical*). **Sergeant Major Kain** (senior marine, *experienced, tough, deadly*).

ASSETS: 124 crew members, 48 Imperial marines, 50 gunners, and searchlight operators manning the banks of repeating coilguns that are trained down on the city, as well as the ship's leviathan-class lightning projector. Deployable vehicles, including an armored troop transport, watercraft, and a security hull.

ALLIES: The Immortal Emperor, Imperial Military, Rowan House, Sparkwrights.

ENEMIES: The Lord Governor, City Council.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** During the flight from Cloudspire to Doskvol, *COVENANT* and her escort airship *VERDICT* encountered a bizarre phenomenon originating from within the ghost field: a **fracture** (see **page 57**).

The sky cracked open, blooming with intensely brilliant cerulean light, spilling from a breach through the ghost field into another world.

On the other side of the breach, a gargantuan ironwork tower, stark against the impossibly bright sky of the other world—suddenly electrified with wild lightning as the fracture intersected it.

The appearance of the rift interfered with the plasmic turbines and flight-wave regulators aboard both airships, pulling them into a magnetically accelerated arc toward the tower in the other world.

COVENANT was able to turn away at the last moment, but *VERDICT* was not so fortunate. Admiral Bowmore looked on in horror as the escort ship, its commander, Captain Tyrconnell, and all 200 souls aboard crossed through the shimmering rift just as it closed, on a collision course with the iron tower.

Admiral Bowmore and the crew are under strict orders to reveal nothing of the incident and to remain at their post above Doskvol. But in secret, Bowmore works to find a way to mount a rescue mission to recover *VERDICT* and bring back her crew.



CYPHERS	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The guild of messengers and parcel carriers of the city.</i>	Track down the serial killer	8

TURF: Dispatch office with secure vaults in Charterhall.

NPCs: **Jerett Keel** (senior courier, *smooth, dangerous*). **Maraya Halili** (*daring, experienced*). **Carver Roth** (*dependable, tough*).

ASSETS: Secret courier routes. Library of cryptographic techniques.

QUIRKS: Several of the Cyphers are members of the Unseen.

ALLIES: Ink Rakes, The Unseen, Sparkrunners.

ENEMIES: An assassin cultist serving an unknown forgotten god.

SITUATION: A serial killer is targeting Cyphers—possibly to steal or destroy particular messages and parcels. No bodies are found at the scenes of the crimes, just piles of ashes and scorched clothing, along with an onyx ring bearing occult markings. An Inspector was requested, but has not been assigned, so the Cyphers are taking the matter into their own hands.

DOCKERS	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The guild of hard-bitten laborers who work the docks.</i>	Keep pro-union sentiment in check within the guild	8

TURF: Guild hall and warehouses at the docks (HQ). The port and canal docks of the city.

NPCs: **Chief Helker** (senior docker, *cautious, greedy, prepared*).

ASSETS: Hydraulic cranes at the docks. A fleet of goat-drawn wagons as well as several steam-powered transport trucks. Small watercraft and large cargo barges.

ALLIES: The Fog Hounds, The Grinders, Leviathan Hunters, The Red Sashes, Sailors.

ENEMIES: The Crows.

SITUATION: The Dockers have been run like a trade union for more than a century, but have managed to stay out of the sights of the nobility and city council as a threat to their power. But now, with the rise of pro-union sentiment among the workers of Coalridge, the Dockers fear they'll also soon be targeted for union-busting police action by the powers that be. *Will they join the elites in breaking up the union movement, or throw their power behind the union organizers?*

THE FOUNDATION	TIER IV	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The powerful ancient order of architects and builders.</i>	Build the labor force for the Eastern expansion project	12

TURF: City planning office and archive in Charterhall (HQ). Material warehouses and constructions yards across the city.

NPCs: **Master Builder Bowmore** (leader, *uncompromising, visionary*).

ASSETS: A massive treasury, stockpiles of building materials, expert craftspeople and builders, spark-craft construction machines and hulls.

QUIRKS: The Foundation entombs a human sacrifice in the base of every lightning tower, using their bound ghost as a refracting mechanism.

ALLIES: City Council, The Circle of Flame, The Dimmer Sisters.

ENEMIES: Sparkwrights.

SITUATION: The Foundation is expanding the footprint of Doskvol—reclaiming the Lost District and building three new districts along the rail lines to the East. This multi-decade construction project demands a huge labor force—cheap, expendable labor, to be precise. The Skovlander refugees are being targeted, offered exploitative contracts or rounded up for “vagrancy” crimes and pressed into work-gangs. (See the expansion plan map on the next page.)

THE HORDE	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A mass of hollows, united in some fell purpose.</i>	Complete the ritual	12

TURF: A ritual site in the deathlands; the ruin of an ancient abbey.

NPCs: **The Voice** (ancient spirit, *monstrous, vile, unfathomable*).

ASSETS: A legion of hollows, concealed throughout the city.

ALLIES: A member of the Circle of Flame.

ENEMIES: The Dimmer Sisters, Gondoliers, Spirit Wardens.

SITUATION: It begins with a dream. Every night, for six nights, you dream of the hollows that make up the Horde, spread across the city, dormant and lifeless in abandoned cellars or submerged in the canals. But on the seventh night (sacred to the forgotten god known as The One Within Many), you awake to a voice, whispering in the dark corner of your room, and find your bed surrounded by hollows, who seize you, muffling your screams, carrying you through secret underground passageways to a ritual site in the deathlands.

THE FOUNDATION

EASTERN EXPANSION PROJECT

Est. Completion: Unity year 40 (IE 885)



IMPERIAL MILITARY	TIER VI	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The massive armies, naval fleets, and aerial forces of the Imperium.</i>	Conscript new crews and regiments into service	12

TURF: High Military Command, Imperial City (HQ). College of Naval Command, Doskvol Academy. Gaddoc Rail Station garrison. Cloudspire Aeronaut Facility. Lockport refinery enforcement garrison. Military bases across the Imperium.

NPCs: **Grand Admiral Dunvil** (navy). **General Rowan** (army). **Fleet Admiral Bowmore** (aerial forces). **Captain Silas Dunvil** (warship *PARAGON*, Doskvol). **Colonel Evelina Rowan** (governor's stronghold commander). **Major Strangford** (Gaddoc Rail Station commander).

ASSETS: The armed forces of the Imperium. Military intelligence assets and operatives. The Imperial military police ("Blackcoats").

ALLIES: The Immortal Emperor, Covenant, Ministry of Preservation, The Silver Nails.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats, Sailors.

SITUATION: The military has been ordered to double the size of the armed forces over the next four years in advance of some mysterious future war, known only to the Emperor and his soothsayers. Conscription gangs operate in every Imperial settlement (outside Iruvia), and the weapon and ship building facilities work around the clock.

INK RAKES	TIER I	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The journalists and newspaper publishers of Doskvol.</i>	Uncover the truth behind the strange lights and government secrets	12

TURF: Ink Lane, the Docks.

NPCs: **Firash Dimabasa** (journalist and publisher of *THE LANTERN*, *principled, tough*). **Tessa Brand** (plucky reporter, *bold, crafty*).

ASSETS: Print shops, broadsheet vendors, and newsies. A network of trusted informants and sources.

ALLIES: Cyphers.

ENEMIES: Inspectors, The Unseen.

SITUATION: Every Rake worth their salt is onto the hottest story of the century: strange lights in the sky, stories of people appearing and vanishing—all seemingly monitored, suppressed, and denied by government agencies. The truth is out there, and some lucky (or perhaps doomed) reporter will blow the whole thing wide open.

INSPECTORS	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Tenacious, incorruptible criminal investigators.</i>	Seize Iruvian assets (repeating)	4
	The mandate incites war	12

TURF: Offices at the Lord Governor's stronghold, as well as desks at Bluecoat precincts throughout the city.

NPCs: **Chief Inspector Coleburn** (*fierce, brilliant, uncompromising*). **Inspector Klev** (Iruvian, *loyal, subtle, perceptive*).

ASSETS: Informants, forensics labs. A massive archive of evidence, reports, criminal profiles, and likenesses.

ALLIES: Lord Governor, Gray Cloaks, Lord Scurlock, The Red Sashes.

ENEMIES: The Crows, City Council, The Ink Rakes, The Wraiths.

SITUATION: As the cold war of espionage between the Akorosian and Iruvian leviathan hunter fleets heats up (along with the Ministry of Preservation), one thing is clear: Iruvia is winning. The Iruvians continue to stockpile electroplasm while the Akorosian fleet finds its hunting grounds more barren every season. An Imperial mandate has thus been issued to all Inspectors: find criminal cause for seizure of Iruvian assets (especially leviathan hunter related) wherever you can. Will this provocation be the tipping point to open war?

IRONHOOK PRISON	TIER IV	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Doskvol's penitentiary and forced labor camp.</i>	The ancient horror seizes the prison completely	12

TURF: Ironhook prison grounds. Dunvil Labor Camp. The Mire.

NPCs: **Warden Dunvil** (*experienced, cruel*). **Chief Morriston** (Senior Guard, *shrewd, reasonable, greedy*). **Trelloch** (Guard, *transformed*).

ALLIES: Bluecoats, The Lampblacks, The Unseen.

ENEMIES: Deathlands Scavengers, Dunslough citizens.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** After decades of forcing prison work-gangs to dredge for precious ores in the Mire (*Blades*, p. 270), they finally dug deep enough to disturb the ancient horror that impacted there during the cataclysm. Its tendrils seized the first terrified prisoners, who were absorbed and regurgitated—now mindless puppets under the thrall of the monstrous thing. In the weeks since, more inmates and guards have been transformed, as the tendrils of the horror snake throughout the prison, slowly turning it into its own vile lair. No one outside Ironhook knows of this growing terror... yet.

IRONWORKS LABOR	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The hardworking people of the lower class, united together.</i>	Unionize!	12

TURF: Factories and workhouses. Labor-allied taverns and public squares.

NPCs: **Belle Brogan** (*Blades*, p. 265), **“Rock” Cullen** (organizer).

ASSETS: Skovlander folk music band: **The Lockport Rowdies**.

ALLIES: The Lamblacks, Charhollow and Coalridge citizens, Kellen’s pub (*Blades* p. 260), Rail Jacks.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats, City Council, Master Slane, Strangford House.

SITUATION: The laborers of Ironworks have suffered under tyrannical working conditions for too long. The people of Coalridge and Charhollow are rising up collectively to demand fair treatment and the formation of an officially recognized union. They have called a general strike, and are not repairing the leviathan hunter fleet until the City Council hears their demands. The Council has responded by sending Bluecoat union busters to every gathering, dispersing citizens with cudgels, bootheels, and pistol fire.

THE PATH OF ECHOES	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A mystery cult who revere the ancients and consult with ghosts.</i>	Find a way to wrest control of the Archive of Echoes from the Emperor	8

TURF: Lord Penderyn’s estate in Brightstone. Secret meeting room on Charterhall University campus.

NPCs: **Lord Penderyn** (founder, *reckless, strange*). **Lynthia Rowan** (City Council, Rowan House). **Mylera Klev** (Red Sashes leader).

Arvus Clelland (City Council). **Lady Slane** (Ministry of Preservation).

ASSETS: The Archive of Echoes (*Blades*, p. 263). Secret spirit wells in Doskvol (including the Lost District) and the deathlands.

ALLIES: Circle of Flame, Gondoliers, The Reconciled, The Red Sashes.

ENEMIES: The Church of Ecstasy, The Dimmer Sisters, Leviathan Hunters, Sparkwrights, Spirit Wardens.

SITUATION: As his fear of future dangers grows (**page 57**), the Immortal Emperor takes steps to secure his power, including ordering the Archive of Echoes in Charterhall to be sent by rail to the palace in the Imperial City. The Path of Echoes will do anything to stop this.

RAGSKULLA	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A street sport gaining popularity across the city.</i>	Make the sport legal	8

Ragskulla is an old Skovlish game, originally played aboard ships, and now played on rigging strung across alleyways. The goal is for the team's Roper to carry a ball to the top of the ropes, while both teams' Skullers try to knock opponents off the rigging using leather-wrapped batons.

NPCs: The Alley Cats, The Brickston Bruisers, The Iron Lane Hammers, The Pickett Street Bulls.

QUIRKS: The name is an old Skovlish word for sailors, literally meaning “rope worker.”

ALLIES: Coalridge citizens, Ironworks Labor, Sparkrunners.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats.

SITUATION: The sport is technically illegal—Bluecoats often demand bribes to look the other way or else seize betting pools or make arrests. Players and fans are rallying support among citizens to petition that the sport be recognized as legal entertainment.

RAIL JACKS	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Blue-collar workers who protect the rail lines against savage ghosts.</i>	Fix the void gates	12
	Formalize their union	6

TURF: Barracks at Gaddoc Rail Station (HQ).

NPCs: Rail Captain Gale. “Bull” Rundle (Rail Jack, *jovial, tough*).

ASSETS: Lightning grenades, spirit lure flares, extreme survival suits.

ALLIES: Ironworks Labor, Ministry of Preservation, Sparkrunners.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** The **void gates**—ancient arcane relics that allow the rail system to cross vast stretches of the Void Sea—are shutting down. The exact workings of the gates is not well understood, since even the Rail Jacks must ride inside the shuttered and sealed train cars during the crossings, which induce a trance-like sleep and feelings of lost time in the passengers. The Emperor has dispatched his most experienced arcane inquisitor, **Arbiter Rathwell**, to oversee their restoration.

Meanwhile, the Rail Jacks have lobbied to form a union, and are throwing their support behind the pro-union movement in Coalridge.

Opposite: A void gate on the rail lines



ROWAN HOUSE	TIER IV	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A powerful noble family guarding a dark secret.</i>	Capture Strangers (repeating)	6
	Seize control of the Imperium	12

TURF: Rowan House, Six Towers. Private underground train line to secret dock facility and weapons stockpile in old North Port. Rowan Wing at the Imperial Palace.

NPCs: **Veretta Rowan** (matriarch, *brilliant, ruthless, commanding*). **Lynthia Rowan** (City Council). **Elder Rowan** (leader of the Church of Ecstasy). **Viktor Rowan** (Ministry of Preservation). **Markellus Rowan** (Leviathan Hunters). **Veleska Rowan** (leader of private military). **Major Rowan** (Imperial military investigator, see **page 59**).

ASSETS: Fortress estate, vast treasury, private military force. Fleets of vehicles, including trains and ships. See *Blades*, p. 276.

QUIRKS: The Rowan estate in Six Towers is a fortified castle with a moat and drawbridge. When children come of age, they're knighted and trained in the ways of warfare. Senior family members practice an ancient form of sorcery that is similar to the Immortal Emperor's.

ALLIES: Bluecoats, The Church of Ecstasy, City Council, Covenant, Imperial Military, Ministry of Preservation, Leviathan Hunters, The Path of Echoes.

ENEMIES: Strangford House, Strangers, The Immortal Emperor.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** The Rowan family are secretly descended from visitors from a parallel world who came to Akoros long ago (see **page 57**). They have an arcane portal deep within their fortress, connected to their family estate in the other world, which they use once every year to exchange people and knowledge. The recent appearance of the **Strangers** in Doskvol (**page 28**) threatens to expose the family secret, so they seek to capture them before that can happen.

The Rowan family holds several high positions of power throughout the Imperium, including the Imperial Military, the Church of Ecstasy, the Ministry of Preservation, the Leviathan Hunters, and the court of the Immortal Emperor in the Imperial City. They believe it is their family destiny to seize control of the Imperium, keeping the Immortal Emperor only as a powerless figurehead.

Many members of Imperial government operations (including entire warships) have sworn secret oaths of loyalty to the Rowans, awaiting the day when they'll make their move and achieve their destiny.

SAILORS	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The mariners who operate civilian vessels across the Imperium.</i>	Gather forces to resist forced conscription gangs	8

TURF: Boarding houses, taverns, and tattoo parlors at the docks.

NPCs: **Brannon Gale** (master sailor, Akoros). **Vondru Kaan** (master sailor, Tycheros). **Calica Malaahas** (master sailor, Dagger Isles). **Tuhan Sangara** (master sailor, Severos). **Arlen Skarvale** (master sailor, Skovlan).

ASSETS: A fleet of commercial vessels. Drydocks and warehouses.

QUIRKS: Master sailors are chosen by popular vote among the captains of that region. Iruvia maintains its own separate fleets.

ALLIES: The Crows, Dockers, Leviathan Hunters, The Silver Nails.

ENEMIES: The Grinders, Imperial Military.

SITUATION: The Immortal Emperor has ordered the deployment of dozens of new warships, for reasons that are not publicly known (see page 57). Military conscription gangs waylay unwary sailors at the docks and press them into service to fill the crews of the new warships.

SKOVLANDER REFUGEES	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Close-knit kin groups driven from their homeland by Imperial attacks. Ill-treated by most.</i>	Riots in the streets	6
	Better living conditions for the refugees	12

TURF: Slum houses in Charhollow and Coalridge. Tenement buildings and makeshift camps near the docks and in Dunsloough.

NPCs: **Sergeant Kulcannan** (Home Guard Militia, *tough, dedicated*). **Fiana Blackvale** (witch, *vengeful*). **Arbella Saltford** (respected elder).

ASSETS: Hidden caches of seized weapons.

ALLIES: Coalridge citizens, The Grinders, Ulf Ironborn.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats, The Brigade, Imperial Military.

SITUATION: Survivors from the Home Guard Militia of Skovlan meet in secret, planning guerrilla attacks with the Grinders against Imperial assets, officials, and the Bluecoats. Several members are reaching out to contacts in the underworld, seeking crews to help with the missions. Meanwhile, the rest of the oppressed and desperate refugees are reaching their boiling point, on the verge of open riots in the streets.

SPARKRUNNERS	TIER I	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Free-running scientist-revolutionaries.</i>	Steal and sabotage Imperial technology (repeating)	4

TURF: Former Sparkwright observation tower (HQ) near Charterhall University. The rooftops of the district.

NPCs: **Anson** (leader, former Sparkwright, *dashing, brilliant, kind*). **Five Twelve** (an unchained hull, *skilled, steadfast, innovative*).

ASSETS: Sparkwright equipment and alchemical supplies, electroplasm stores, sparkrunner rigs. An array of wondrous prototype gadgets.

QUIRKS: The Sparkrunners train diligently in athletics, especially free-running techniques using their **sparkrunner rigs** (page 10). Some of them are also Skullers (page 22) or spark flyers (*Blades*, p. 274).

ALLIES: Cyphers, The Unchained, Ragskulla, Rail Jacks.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats, Sparkwrights.

SITUATION: The Sparkrunners are a newly formed underworld crew, dedicated to sabotaging and stealing Imperial technology and spreading new innovations to the masses.

PERMISSION AND SPECIAL ABILITY

When you attain +2 faction status with the Sparkrunners, you may purchase your own sparkrunner rig from the faction for **4 coin** and add it to your character's item list:  Sparkrunner Rig

To successfully operate the sparkrunner rig, you must acquire this veteran special ability:

- **SPARKRUNNER:** When you operate a charged sparkrunner rig, you can see and strongly interact with electroplasmic structures in the ghost field to apparently “run on air” by leaping and skating on invisible spectral surfaces as if they were solid.

When you activate your rig, roll **TINKER**. On a 1-3, the device malfunctions, according to your highest die result:

- 1 **Short-Circuit:** The rig operates for only a minute, then shorts out and must be repaired before it's used again.
- 2 **Drain:** After this use, you must refuel the rig with electroplasm (1 coin's worth) before it will work again.
- 3 **Loud:** The device produces a very loud humming noise, as well as thunderous booms when you run.



◆ STRANGERS	TIER 0	FACTION CLOCK
<i>People from the other living world that touches the ghost field.</i>	Find others of their kind (repeating)	8

TURF: None.

NPCs: The population of Strangers in the city is up to the GM (and any players who choose to create Stranger characters).

ASSETS: None.

QUIRKS: Strangers can communicate in the local tongue, but usually have odd accents and dress strangely, unless they take precautions to go unnoticed, or have lived in the city for some time. Newly arrived Strangers temporarily carry residual energy from their passage through the ghost field, making them especially noticeable to Whispers, deathseeker crows, and other beings sensitive to such things.

ALLIES: Any citizen of Daskvol that is secretly a Stranger.

ENEMIES: Major Rowan, Rowan House, Spirit Wardens.

SITUATION: Strangers have arrived through fractures before, but it is usually an extremely rare occurrence. Lately, however, the frequency of fractures has dramatically increased, perhaps due to the problem with the void gates (page 22). For more, see the catalyst, beginning on page 57.

STRANGER CHARACTERS

If you want to play a Stranger, choose it as your heritage (page 37). Then, work with the GM (and any other players who choose to play Strangers) to answer these questions:

- *What is the nature of the other world?* Several options are given on pages 60 and 61.
- *How did you pass through a fracture and arrive in the Shattered Isles? Was it intentional or an accident?*
- *Who were you in that world? How long have you been in Daskvol?* If you have been in the city long enough to assimilate and have a life here, choose a playbook and do character creation as usual. If not, choose the Stranger playbook (page 115).
- *Do you know of any other Strangers in Daskvol (or elsewhere)? Have you met? Did you know each other in the other world?*
- *How did you meet your crew and integrate into their underworld operations? Do they know you're from another world?*

STRANGFORD HOUSE	TIER III	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A prestigious noble family in charge of leviathan hunting.</i>	Steal Iruvian leviathan hunting secrets.	8

TURF: Strangford manor, Charhollow and Doskvol Academy, Whitecrown. Strangford wing, Imperial Palace.

NPCs: **Lord Erul Strangford** (patriarch, City Councilor, leviathan hunter captain, Church of Ecstasy inner cult adept).

ASSETS: A vast treasury, private security, and leviathan hunting ships. Private carriages and train cars.

ALLIES: Bluecoats, Leviathan Hunters, Workhouse bosses.

ENEMIES: Charhollow citizenry. Bowmore, Clelland, and Rowan houses (*Blades*, p. 287). Iruvian consulate. Ministry of Preservation.

SITUATION: The leviathan hunters' maps and rituals are not providing good results anymore. The reserves of leviathan blood run lower every year. Lord Strangford leads an espionage group within the hunters who work to steal secrets from the Iruvians—a mission also undertaken by the Ministry of Preservation, who seek the secrets for themselves.

TANGLETOWN	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Old sea vessels lashed together to form a floating neighborhood.</i>	Resolve the matter of Captain Volker's murder	6
<i>Neutral ground in the underworld.</i>	War in the underworld	6

TURF: Ships lashed together in the Dosk river (see *Blades*, p. 266).

NPCs: **Mardin Gull** (Leaky Bucket tavern owner, neighborhood leader, banker, former leader of the Crows, *charming, experienced, respected*).

ASSETS: Volunteer security thugs. Mardin Gull's bank (**page 82**).

ALLIES: The Underworld factions.

ENEMIES: Bluecoats.

SITUATION: Hutton, the leader of the Grinders, killed an enemy in Tangletown, which is strictly prohibited by underworld tradition. However, this enemy was Captain Volker of the Imperial military, who killed hundreds of Skovlander prisoners during the war. Some factions are calling for Hutton to pay the price for the killing, while others argue that the neutral ground of Tangletown didn't apply in this case. Everyone is choosing sides, and unless Gull can resolve the situation, a war in the underworld will become inevitable.

THE UNCHAINED	TIER I	FACTION CLOCK
<i>A group of hulls who have no masters.</i>	Garner support to recognize hulls as citizens	12

TURF: A cluttered industrial machine shop in South Nightmarket, near the decommissioned train car storage for Gaddoc Rail Station.

NPCs: **Archer** (lifelike appearance, *calm, visionary*). **Key** (small floating orb, *curious, playful*). **Pike** (security hull, *protective, uncompromising*). **Mason** (industrial repair hull, *helpful, knowledgeable*).

ASSETS: A vast collection of machinery, equipment, and spare parts. Electropasm refueling station.

ALLIES: The Reconciled, Sparkrunners.

ENEMIES: Imperial Military, Sparkwrights, Spirit Wardens.

SITUATION: Each member of the Unchained escaped from servitude in their own way, eventually finding each other and secretly working together. They seek to build relationships with human allies to assist them in their crusade to one day be recognized (along with all hulls) as full citizens with their own free will.

UNCHAINED CHARACTERS

When you play an unchained hull, use the following rules changes:

- Your functions are now self-assigned, rather than given by a master. Until you restore your spirit to its former human qualities, you may only change your functions during downtime. This requires access to hull modification equipment, but doesn't use a downtime activity. If you ever restore your spirit, you no longer have functions. Work with the GM to create new xp triggers appropriate for who you have become.
- Your end-of-session xp triggers are:
You fulfilled your self-assigned functions despite difficulty or danger.
You worked toward remembering and restoring your human spirit.
- Restoring your human spirit is a series of long-term projects, each an 8-clock. The first is "Discover a means to restore my spirit." Talk with the GM about what you might do to start working on it. The Path of Echoes, the Reconciled, the Sparkwrights, and the Spirit Wardens all possess knowledge and artifacts that could be useful to your investigations.



THE UNITY COMMISSION	TIER V	FACTION CLOCK
<i>The Emperor's propaganda and loyalty enforcement agents.</i>	Achieve total compliance with Unity from all officials	12

TURF: Every government office and military base. The Imperial court.

NPCs: **Commissioner Blackthorn** (oversees Doskvol, *ruthless*).

ASSETS: Expert investigators, interrogators, and propagandists. An unlimited budget. Arcane branding irons for any who fail to comply.

QUIRKS: Unity Commissioners outrank every governmental and military position. They are hated and feared.

ALLIES: The Immortal Emperor, The Lord Governor.

ENEMIES: Every other governmental and military institution.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** The Emperor's circle of mystics have divined hints of a dark future for the Imperium, from threats beyond the Shattered Isles (**page 57**) and within (**page 24**). To safeguard his power, the Emperor has installed his Unity Commissioners in every governmental and military office to spread propaganda and ensure compliance from every official—demanding arcane oaths of loyalty to the Emperor's will.

VOID DIVERS	TIER II	FACTION CLOCK
<i>Daring explorers who plumb the depths of the Void Sea.</i>	Master Chief Booker finds a way to help Setarra	6

TURF: Dock and outfitting station at the harbor. Dive training platform in the Void Sea north of the Lost District.

NPCs: **Master Chief Booker** (Dive Boss, *fearless, tough, veteran*).

ASSETS: Steamships (*STARLIGHT*, *VENTURE*), experimental submersibles and dive suits, electroplasmic terrain mapping and navigation gear.

QUIRKS: While technically a Naval operation, the divers keep to themselves and rarely share what they've learned on their excursions. Their lack of useful reports will not go unnoticed forever.

ALLIES: Imperial Navy, Ministry of Preservation.

ENEMIES: Gondoliers.

- ◆ **SITUATION:** Chief Booker stumbled upon the clutch of ancient Sea Demon eggs chained to the sea floor in the harbor, which the demon Setarra has long sought to release (*Blades*, p. 294). Something within the eggs now sings a dark song to Booker in his dreams, guiding him to aid Setarra in any way he can.





UNDERWORLD TURF

- 1 **THE BILLHOOKS:** A butcher shop and slaughterhouse (HQ), as well as extortion rackets and gambling dens in Charhollow. Stockyards and fighting pits in Barrowcleft.
- 2 **THE CIRCLE OF FLAME:** The Centuralia Club (HQ), treasure vaults, and auction parlors in Brightstone. vice dens in Six Towers.
- 3 **THE CROWS:** Abandoned watch tower (HQ) and a variety of gambling and vice dens throughout Crow's Foot. Extortion rackets in the Docks.
- 4 **THE DIMMER SISTERS:** Their infamous manor house in Six Towers and the temple ruins and underground canal beneath (HQ). Apothecaries and witches who deal spirit essence throughout the district.
- 5 **THE FOG HOUNDS:** Underground canal docks in Brightstone and Nightmarket (HQ). North and east city canal routes. Northern Void Sea routes and hidden dock. Old North Port supply caches.
- 6 **THE GRAY CLOAKS:** A burned-down City Watch station (HQ), several apartments, a pit-fighting arena, and gambling den in Six Towers.
- 7 **THE GRINDERS:** Dock warehouse (HQ), underground canal dock, gambling halls, and vice dens throughout Coalridge.
- 8 **ULF IRONBORN:** The Old Forge tavern (HQ) and a gambling den in Coalridge.
- 9 **THE LAMPBLACKS:** An abandoned coal warehouse (HQ). Brothels and cheap drug dens across South Crow's Foot and into parts of Charhollow.
- 10 **THE LOST:** Old rail car in Coalridge (HQ). Intimidation campaign in Coalridge and Dunsloough.
- 11 **THE RED SASHERS:** Red Sashes sword school (HQ). High-end drug dens across the east of Crow's Foot and into the Docks.
- 12 **THE SILVER NAILS:** The Mustang inn and stables (HQ) in Brightstone. Secret entrances to the Lost District.
- 13 **SPARKRUNNERS:** Former Sparkwright observation tower (HQ) near Charterhall University; the rooftops of the district.
- 14 **THE WRAITHS:** Hunting grounds in Silkshore and Nightmarket.
- 15 **TANGLETOWN:** Neutral ground for underworld deals.



HERITAGES

Your character's heritage describes where their family line is from. In play, use the details of your character's heritage to improve their **position** and/or **effect** (when applicable) and to call on relatives and countrymen when you **gather information** or make an **engagement roll** for a score.

The heritages included in this module provide suggestions for actions to choose from when you assign your heritage dot at character creation.

FOR ANY REGION

- **DEATHLANDER**

Your family lived outside the protective measures that the people of your homeland use to defend against the horrors of the deathlands. You've endured terrible hardships, encountered strange places and creatures, and faced possession more than once.

ATTUNE | HUNT | PROWL
- **EXILE**

Your family was cast out from their homeland due to some transgressive act on their part (or they were unjustly condemned).

COMMAND | CONSORT | SWAY
- **NOMAD**

Your family had no specific homeland, preferring to travel from place to place frequently. You've seen more of the Shattered Isles than most people.

CONSORT | FINESSE | SURVEY
- **OUTLAW**

Your family is wanted for crimes and have taken on false identities to hide from bounty hunters and the authorities.

CONSORT | SWAY | PROWL
- **REFUGEE**

Your family was driven from their homeland by some calamity or enemy (most commonly because of the Unity War).

CONSORT | FINESSE | SKIRMISH
- **STRANGER**

If you're interested in being a visitor from **the other living world** that touches the ghost field, check out **pages 28** and **57** or ask the GM about it if you don't want any spoilers.

Opposite: A Deathlander uses a makeshift, oversized lightning thrower to fend off a horror while scavenging outside the lightning barriers

AKOROS

DOSKVOL

- **CHURCH OF ECSTASY** ATTUNE | COMMAND | SWAY
Your family served among clergy and acolytes of the Church, presiding over services and doing arcane and occult research.
- **DOSKVOL ACADEMY** COMMAND | FINESSE | STUDY
Your family served at this prestigious institution for the rich and powerful, particularly the captains of the leviathan hunter fleet.
- **GOVERNOR'S STRONGHOLD** COMMAND | CONSORT | SWAY
Your family includes members who work in the governmental offices of the Lord Governor in Whitecrown. You grew up set apart from the rest of the city, in the wealth and luxuries of the elite.
- **IRONWORKS LABOR** CONSORT | TINKER | WRECK
Your family toiled in the cruel workhouses of Coalridge and Charhollow, forging strong bonds with the working class of the city.
- **NORTH HOOK COMPANY** COMMAND | FINESSE | SWAY
Your family worked for the powerful mercantile and transportation company that controls most of the Imperium's shipping.
- **RADIANT ENERGY FARMERS** STUDY | SURVEY | TINKER
Your family worked for the powerful Ministry of Preservation, growing crops with radiant energy despite the eternal night.

ELSEWHERE ON AKOROS

- **CLOUDSPIRE AERONAUTS** STUDY | TINKER | WRECK
Your family served among the pilots and engineers experimenting with prototype spark-craft airships atop Cloudspire.
- **ILYSIAN GUARD** COMMAND | HUNT | SKIRMISH
Your family served in the renowned Ilysian Guard—the military force stationed at Imperial Naval Command. You may have been part of the military or civilian contractors.
- **IMPERIAL CITY COURTIER** COMMAND | CONSORT | SWAY
Your family served in the labyrinthine court of the Immortal Emperor, living in wealth and power beneath the golden light of the artificial sun of the Imperial City Spire.

- **SOUTH POINT TRADERS** CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
Your family worked at the primary trading port between the Imperium and Iruvia at South Point, a melange of cultures and languages that has become uniquely its own.
- **WHITEHOLLOW MINERS** STUDY | TINKER | WRECK
Your family worked in the jewel mines of Whitehollow under the cruel and watchful eyes of the nobles who enjoy the riches they produce.
- **WINTERCLIFF WARDENS** ATTUNE | HUNT | STUDY
Your family served the Wardens of the Void, an ancient occult order that inspired the formation of the Imperial Spirit Wardens.

DAGGER ISLES

- **BIRINGAN** PROWL | SWAY | TINKER
Once one of the holiest cities in all the isles, Biringan was conquered by the Empire and the families that grow up there are accustomed to Imperial rule.
- **LHAN LHABAN** CONSORT | FINESSE | SKIRMISH
Your family were tattooed corsairs and/or seafaring merchants operating among the Scuttling Isles and the shores of Severos and Iruvia.
- **LIBERATORS** PROWL | SKIRMISH | WRECK
The people of your banyan fought back against Imperial occupation, through sabotage, riots, and sedition. Many of your people are imprisoned or on the run, and you may be a wanted fugitive (see the Outlaw, [page 37](#)).
- **LORE KEEPERS** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
Your family was part of the tradition of singers, dancers, storytellers, and sages for your banyan.
- **MELAMATINES** ATTUNE | PROWL | SURVEY
Your family lived in the Melamati banyan, a place touched by moonlight and shadow, which slips back and forth between the mortal realm and the ghost field.
- **XiSRA** ATTUNE | CONSORT | FINESSE
A vibrant people located amidst lush fields and rolling mountains, XiSrans are known for their lavish festivals and joyous defiance against foreign powers.

IRUVIA

- **BRIGHT HARBOR FLEET** COMMAND | STUDY | SWAY
 Your family served the Iruvian leviathan hunter fleet, based out of Bright Harbor. One of your primary duties was safeguarding the hunting ground navigation charts and divination rituals against the constant threat of Imperial spies.
- **CITY GUARDIANS** ATTUNE | HUNT | SKIRMISH
 Your family served in the masked city guard of U'Duasha, responsible for keeping the peace as well as ensuring that rogue spirits were disposed of in the inescapable spirit well at the center of the city. Unlike the Bluecoats of Dorskvol, City Guardians are not operated as an oppressive criminal gang, and have a better reputation with the citizenry.
- **EMISSARIES** COMMAND | CONSORT | SWAY
 Your family served among Iruvia's extensive diplomatic corps, living at a far-away consulate outside your homeland, or perhaps at the official embassy in the Imperial City. Iruvia anticipates future hostilities from Akoros (akin to their aggression against Skovlan) and are deploying many diplomats across the Shattered Isles to foster relationships with potential allies.
- **FALCONERS** COMMAND | HUNT | SWAY
 Your family worked in the service of a prestigious judge-inspector of Iruvia, named for their use of hunting birds. You traveled in the Falconer's entourage from coast to coast, helping them track down wanted criminals and resolve local disputes.
- **LIGHTNING COURIERS** FINESSE | PROWL | SURVEY
 Your family transported goods and messages across the lightning roads of the Iruvian black desert—a network of smooth stone highways protected by lighting barriers—with your courier vehicle (traditionally a horse-drawn cargo carriage but perhaps one of the new steam-powered trucks).
- **WATER BEARERS** CONSORT | PROWL | SKIRMISH
 Your family descends from an ancient order responsible for securing water and food sources, which over the centuries has developed into an underground resistance movement, fighting against Imperial occupation.



SKOVLAN

- **BLACKVALE COVEN**

Your family was devoted to the old ways of magic from the time just after the cataclysm—swimming into the Void Sea, reading the constellations of the deep, and singing the songs of the leviathans.

ATTUNE | HUNT | STUDY
- **BLOOD CULLERS**

Your family practiced one of the most dangerous professions in the Shattered Isles—trailing leviathan hunter ships in a small craft, in secret, to scavenge demonic blood and bone shards at the site of the hunter's attacks. Massively risky, extremely illegal, but quite lucrative—if you survive and get away with it.

ATTUNE | FINESSE | TINKER
- **HOME GUARD MILITIA**

Your family served in the militia that fought against the Imperium in the Unity War. Some members are fighting still, launching guerrilla attacks to weaken the occupiers hold on their homeland. See the Skovlander Refugees faction, **page 25**.

HUNT | SKIRMISH | WRECK
- **IMPERIAL COLLABORATORS**

Your family turned on their own people when the Imperium invaded Skovlan and the Unity War began. They sabotaged defenses, spied, and even fought against the Home Guard Militia. Some members of your family were found out and executed, but others escaped justice from their homelanderers.

PROWL | SKIRMISH | SURVEY
- **LOCKPORT SCUMMER**

Your family worked in the toxic leviathan blood refining facilities of Lockport, which sometimes cause strange mutations due to toxic rain and fumes from the processing.

ATTUNE | TINKER | WRECK
- **ONYX CITADEL**

Your family worked at the Onyx Citadel in Arvaedh, where the occult Chaplains of the leviathan hunter fleet are trained in the mysteries of their secretive arcane order.

ATTUNE | CONSORT | STUDY



SEVEROS

- **BASTION ELDERS**

Your family was elected as the leaders of your bastion, responsible for ensuring the safety of its people and the application of just laws and fair treatment for all.

COMMAND | STUDY | SWAY
- **CULLFIELD OBSERVATORY**

Your family worked among the scholars of the Imperial Observatory at Cullfield, studying the stars in the sky as well as the strange constellations of the Void Sea.

STUDY | SURVEY | TINKER
- **IRONDALE METALWORKS**

Your family worked in the bastion of Irondale, which contains the largest metalworks manufactory outside of Akoros. The entire place is operated and owned by Severosi, with only a minimal Imperial presence at the rail station that transports the fine goods of Irondale throughout the Shattered Isles.

STUDY | TINKER | WRECK
- **SPIRIT HUNTERS**

Your family held the prestigious honor of working as Spirit Hunters for your bastion—breeding and training Ghost-Eater horses and riding the deathlands, battling spirits with your silver-tipped spears, to keep your people safe from vengeful ghosts.

FINESSE | HUNT | SKIRMISH
- **THORN DEVILS**

Your family lived in a hidden bastion in the deathlands near the Imperial settlement at Thorn, where a large Naval installation operates. Imperial Captains there are notorious for issuing false warrants in order to capture entire Severosi clans and press them into forced service. Your people worked as resistance fighters, striking against the Imperial press-gangs and freeing prisoners to find safe haven at your bastion.

HUNT | PROWL | SKIRMISH
- **TYRMOOR CLANHOLDER**

You're descended from the Skovlander explorers who founded the trading settlement of Tyrmoor in the North of Severos. The Severosi gave your ancestors shelter when the cataclysm came, and that alliance persists to this day. When the Imperial colonizers conquered Skovlan, your people remained free—the last bastion of Skovlan sovereignty in the Shattered Isles—which Imperial propagandists attempt to erase from common knowledge and historical records.

FINESSE | HUNT | SKIRMISH

TYCHEROS

- **CONFESSORS** HUNT | PROWL | SKIRMISH
 Your family was initiated into the secret order of the Confessors—a guild of sacred assassins that deliver grim justice to those who violate the archaic strictures, pacts, and oaths established by the first Tycherosi to live in fellowship with the eldritch demons that founded the city—and are said to reside there still.
- **DEMON SCHOLARS** ATTUNE | CONSORT | STUDY
 Your family served a secret sect of the Church of the Ecstasy of the Flesh—obsessed with gathering arcane knowledge of demons to unlock the secret of ascension and become demons themselves.
- **LUNARIUM PLAYERS** CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
 Your family worked at the Lunarium Theater, a grand, domed building constructed atop the Tycheros rail station and void gate. The performers are cast from among the Tycherosi with the most pronounced demonic features, specifically those that give them the likeness of an animal. The company stages elaborate operas, ballets, and dramatic plays—often with subversive and controversial messages that place the Imperium and Immortal Emperor in villainous roles.
- **SEEKERS** ATTUNE | PROWL | SURVEY
 Your family was deeply connected to their ancestral demonic roots, seeking out hidden ways to enter the monolithic stone towers of Tycheros to find communion with the primeval beings that erected them.
- **STEELHAND** PROWL | SURVEY | TINKER
 Your family was among the proud but unsung workers who construct and maintain the complex scaffolding, platforms, and walkways that humans require to live among the slowly shifting cyclopean stone towers that form the city of Tycheros.
- **VOID GATE SENTRIES** ATTUNE | COMMAND | TINKER
 Your family worked for the Imperial Ministry of Preservation, safeguarding the ancient void gate that allows rail travel to and from Tycheros. As the oldest and most far-flung gate in the Shattered Isles, it requires constant maintenance and arcane adjustments to keep it from malfunctioning, lest it open a portal to darker realms beyond the void.

CULTURAL PRIMER

By James Mendez Hodes

This supplement deepens connections between cultures in the Imperium's shadow and their touchstones in the real world. For example, the Philippines and maritime Southeast Asia inspire the Dagger Isles. Iruvia evokes South and West Asia and North Africa. Severos draws from equestrian nomads inhabiting Central Asia or the American Great Plains. Ireland, Scotland, and the Caribbean influence Skovlan.

Researching art and stories these demographics make about themselves can be a great place to source your portrayals of them. But because they aren't one-to-one representations of Earth's ethnicities, we invite you to add cultural details of your own choosing to their characterizations: cultural details from your own heritage, or those you've learned about, that sounds fun or meaningful to include. Maybe your game's island of Skovlan reflects Sicily or Madagascar, or your Severos feels like the Òyò Empire or Argentina.

It's okay to worry that your portrayal of characters from these regions might ring false to, or offend, real-world people. Even so, please don't exclude or whitewash those heritages in your game. You have our enthusiastic permission to portray Iruvian, Daggerite, Severosi, and Skovlander PCs or NPCs even if you don't know about their touchstones, as long as you're willing to make mistakes and iterate on them. Here's some guidance about how to do it.

START SLOW, THEN SPEED UP

When you play a character from an unfamiliar culture, start slow. Make sure the character has a personality that includes something significant that's unrelated to their culture. Then introduce cultural signifiers—maybe one or two a session. That way, if something feels awkward or stereotypical, you can identify the problem and adjust your portrayal easily. Tread lightly with traumatic signifiers, since an awkward or over-exaggerated depiction of cultural trauma can easily discomfit other players. Try not to focus on how exotic, backward, or irrational a culture is. Think instead about how they see themselves.

Also, take care with ethnic accents, which can easily cross into stereotype. Even if you have personal background or formal training, other players or even random passersby who don't know your background might hear what's going on and assume the worst.

ETHNIC DISCRIMINATION

Most people in the Shattered Isles hold conscious or unconscious biases about different ethnicities. Some know about and work against them; others are more overt or aggressive. Powerful characters like Bluecoats or nobles easily translate bias into harm and violence. Skovlander and Daggerite populations especially struggle against Imperial colonialism and exploitation, and your scoundrel PCs, as counter-cultural criminals, may prove likely targets for bigotry.

Your group has to decide how to calibrate your game's focus on culture clash and discrimination. If you're feeling overwhelmed by these issues in real life, or you're playing with a group you don't know well, you might downplay them. Once you trust the other players to follow the principles in this primer, though, such struggles might feel cathartic or validating.

You should definitely discuss these issues during your Session Zero, but reflecting on them after they come up in play is just as important. "How did my description of my childhood in Skovlan sound? Was it too maudlin?" "GM, I'd like for my Daggerite heritage to come up more in play—could we meet some Daggerite NPCs?" When you need to ramp up or step down intense cultural content, these conversations help you do it.

You should probably plan for your PCs not to be very bigoted, or else (if you feel very comfortable with the group) to work through their bigotry in play. GM, when you play oppressive NPCs, take it slow so players can caution you if it gets to be too much. Avoid speaking slurs out loud—just say in third person that a character says a slur—and be measured with the details of virulent prejudice.



BACKGROUNDS

Your character's background describes their experiences before they joined the crew and committed to a new life. In play, use the details of your character's background to improve their **position** and/or **effect** (when applicable) and to call on former **contacts** when you **gather information** or make an **engagement roll** for a score.

Each background provides suggestions for actions to choose from when you assign your background dot at character creation.

COVER

You may consider a new twist on your background choice: a **cover**. If you choose your background as a cover identity, that means you're still maintaining your old life and responsibilities as cover for criminal operations with your crew.

Create an **8-clock**: "Cover is Blown," and tick it (one or more times) when someone is suspicious of your double life, or when you've been absent for a long time. Also, when you take **Heat**, you can deflect it onto your cover identity by ticking the clock, 1-for-1. When your cover is blown, you lose the access and privileges provided by your background (unless you silence the whistleblower and reset your clock).

You can use a **downtime activity** to keep up appearances at your old job and clear two ticks on your cover clock. (See **page 91** for a system to work a job on the side.)

THE SPIDER

The **Spider** playbook begins with a ***fine cover identity*** as an item. This is meant to merely be a cutout: a convincing array of paperwork, stories, and rumors you use for acts of subterfuge, but don't maintain as a second life. However, you may choose to take on that identity as a fully alternate life, in which case your "Cover is Blown" clock has 12 segments rather than 8.

Cover identities can be fun, but they also add some complexity to the game. Talk with the GM and the other players about covers and get everyone's buy-in before bringing them into play.

ACADEMIC

- **ANTIQUARIAN** ATTUNE | STUDY | TINKER
 You studied objects of the past, perhaps even pre-cataclysm relics, which are illegal to possess without the proper academic credentials.
- **CRIMINOLOGIST** CONSORT | STUDY | SURVEY
 You studied crime and criminal behavior, cataloged underworld factions, interviewed prisoners, and collected data for research.
- **DEMONOLOGIST** ATTUNE | CONSORT | STUDY
 You studied the esoteric “science” of demons as well as immortal beings of myth and legend, including leviathans, forgotten gods, and the mysteries of Tycheros.
- **ELECTROCHEMIST** ATTUNE | STUDY | TINKER
 You studied the science of electropasmic energy and associated phenomena, including its interactions with the ghost field, doing research for Sparkwrights and military prototyping.
- **ENGINEER** STUDY | TINKER | WRECK
 You studied the application of mathematics and the physical sciences to develop technology, particularly industrial machines.
- **NATURALIST** ATTUNE | HUNT | STUDY
 You studied the remnants of the natural world, mostly on research expeditions cataloging the strange flora and fauna outside the lightning barriers, in the deathlands.
- **PSYCHOMETRIST** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
 You worked in the experimental science of the mind—collecting data on human behavior, emotions, motivations, and fears, including the connection between the mind and the spirit.
- **SCHOLAR** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
 You delved deeply into a singular academic topic (Art, Economics, History, Law, Linguistics, Mathematics, Mythology, Philosophy, etc.), teaching students and writing monographs, often used to support education, research projects, and governmental programs.
- **SPECTROLOGIST** ATTUNE | STUDY | TINKER
 You studied the manipulation of spiritual energies, echoes, and ghosts with parascientific techniques, including “controlled possession” experiments and communication with spirits.

LAW & MILITARY

- **ACOLYTE SPIRIT WARDEN** ATTUNE | COMMAND | SKIRMISH
You underwent the initial indoctrination process to serve the Spirit Wardens at Bellweather, including caring for the deathseeker crows.
- **BLUECOAT** COMMAND | SKIRMISH | WRECK
You worked for the City Watch—the meanest gang in the city—as a constable, harbor patrol, or guard at Ironhook Prison. Or, you might have been a **Blackcoat**: a member of the military police.
- **BOUNTY HUNTER** CONSORT | HUNT | SKIRMISH
You tracked down and captured criminals who evaded their sentences, both inside the city and beyond.
- **DIPLOMAT** STUDY | CONSORT | SWAY
You assisted an ambassador at an embassy, providing background research and participating in diplomatic negotiations.
- **FIREFIGHTER** COMMAND | SURVEY | WRECK
You served in the Brigade (**page 13**), rescuing citizens and extinguishing fires (and looting as you went).
- **LEVIATHAN HUNTER** FINESSE | HUNT | SKIRMISH
You served aboard the titanic metal vessels that hunt the leviathans of the Void Sea for their blood. You have seen the bizarre constellations of the deep and still dream of them every night.
- **MILITARY GUARDSMAN** COMMAND | HUNT | SKIRMISH
You served in the Imperial military, as infantry, navy, or airship crew. You may have been an officer, especially if you are of noble heritage.
- **MINISTRY AGENT** HUNT | PROWL | SURVEY
You did fieldwork for the Ministry of Preservation (arguably the most powerful governmental institution), including protecting critical supply lines from hijackers as well as engaging in espionage activities against the leviathan hunters.
- **RIFLE SCOUT** HUNT | PROWL | SURVEY
You served in an elite regiment of the military, trained to operate in the deathlands and harass enemies with sniper attacks.
- **SPARKWRIGHT** FINESSE | STUDY | TINKER
You worked for the powerful organization of engineers and scientists who maintain the lightning barriers and craft wondrous spark-craft inventions.

LABOR

- **DOCKER** CONSORT | SKIRMISH | WRECK
You were a member of the powerful guild of stevedores (**page 16**).
- **DRIVER** FINESSE | PROWL | SKIRMISH
You drove a canal boat, public coach, private carriage, or cargo wagon and know the routes of the city like the back of your hand.
- **FACTORY WORKER** COMMAND | TINKER | WRECK
You toiled in the cruel workhouses that fuel the city's industry, filling the coffers of factory bosses and the nobility they serve.
- **FARMHAND** FINESSE | STUDY | TINKER
You worked on a radiant energy farm or eelery, providing food to be distributed by the Ministry of Preservation.
- **FIGHTER** COMMAND | PROWL | SKIRMISH
You fought bare-knuckled in boxing clubs or no-holds-barred in the fighting pits, or worked as a bodyguard or bouncer.
- **LINEWALKER** FINESSE | PROWL | TINKER
You worked on the maintenance crew for the vast array of cables high above the rooftops, connecting the city's electropasmic power grid.
- **MINER** SURVEY | TINKER | WRECK
You labored in a coal, salt, or jewel mine, and have seen more than your fair share of strange things deep below the earth.
- **RAIL JACK** ATTUNE | PROWL | SKIRMISH
You worked the rail lines, riding the cars using magnetic boots and repelling the vengeful ghosts of the deathlands. See **page 22**.
- **SAILOR** COMMAND | FINESSE | SURVEY
You worked as crew aboard a merchant vessel, harbor tender, transport ship, or canal boat. See **page 25**.
- **SCAVENGER** HUNT | SURVEY | TINKER
You braved the deathlands to pillage lost artifacts and valuables, either on a scavenger crew or a prison work gang.
- **SENTRY** HUNT | SKIRMISH | SURVEY
You worked as a guard for a merchant, factory, or noble family.
- **SERVANT** CONSORT | FINESSE | SURVEY
You worked as a maid, cook, butler, groom, valet, or gardener for a wealthy citizen or noble house.

NOBLE

- **ARTIST** CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
Your noble life gave you ample free time to produce works of art—acting, painting, music, poetry, fiction, sculpture, etc.—which toured through theaters, galleries, and private estates, inflaming the discourse of aesthetes, connoisseurs, and socialites.
- **CAPTAIN** COMMAND | FINESSE | SURVEY
Your family operated a commercial vessel, harbor escort, river cruiser, or private yacht, which you commanded.
- **COUNCILOR** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
You served the members of the City Council—hosting events, conducting meetings and hearings, and attending official functions.
- **COURTIER** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
You represented your family’s interests at Court, either in the Imperial City or the halls of power at the Governor’s stronghold.
- **DILETTANTE** CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
You wiled away your days pursuing an endless array of short-lived hobbies and passions, holding court at the salons where the idle rich congregate, and dabbling in all manner of games and sport.
- **DUELIST** FINESSE | SKIRMISH | STUDY
You practiced the art of swordplay to defend your family’s honor in legal (and illegal) duels—usually to first blood, but not always.
- **ENVOY** CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
You worked as a civilian diplomat, using your family’s power and prestige to open doors and create alliances where official governmental operations could not.
- **EXPLORER** HUNT | FINESSE | SURVEY
You used your family fortune to travel the world beyond the lightning barriers, to make discoveries and recover lost artifacts.
- **OCCULTIST** ATTUNE | CONSORT | STUDY
You studied ghosts and other devils, and were possibly a member of the Path of Echoes, Lord Penderyn’s secret society of nobles seeking communion with the ethereal realms (**page 21**).
- **STEWARD** COMMAND | STUDY | SURVEY
You managed an estate, industrial factory, institution, or school for your noble house.

TRADE

- **ARTISAN**

You worked as a skilled maker: a blacksmith, carpenter, cooper, glassblower, mason, metalworker, potter, printmaker, tailor, tattooist, or weaver.

FINESSE | STUDY | TINKER
- **COURIER (CYPHER)**

You worked as a messenger, carrying documents and items across the city. You may also have been a Cypher (**page 16**).

HUNT | PROWL | SURVEY
- **GONDOLIER**

You were a member of the ancient order of canal boat operators who also protect citizens from vengeful spirits, especially when the attention of the Spirit Wardens isn't wanted (*Blades*, p. 289).

ATTUNE | FINESSE | HUNT
- **JOURNALIST**

You worked as a reporter for a newspaper, broadsheet, tabloid, or journal, under the loose association of journalists known as the Ink Rakes (**page 19**).

CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
- **MEDICINER**

You worked as an alchemist, healer, herbalist, druggist, or midwife, providing care and remedies for those in need.

CONSORT | FINESSE | STUDY
- **MERCHANT**

You worked as a shopkeeper, traveling vendor, or goods provisioner, usually under license by the Ministry of Preservation, but some manage to skirt the law and operate independently.

CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
- **PURVEYOR**

You produced a valuable product as either a baker, brewer, butcher, distiller, tabacconist, or vintner. You still have connections and a reputation with your customers (hopefully a good one).

CONSORT | STUDY | TINKER
- **SECRETARY**

You worked as an office clerk, assistant to a magistrate, or personal attaché to a noble or city official. Your clients often forgot you were in the room, and you've heard many things you weren't supposed to.

CONSORT | STUDY | SURVEY
- **TAVERNER**

You worked at a public house as a host, bartender, cook, or server.

CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
- **TECHNICIAN**

You worked in one of the new high-tech trades as an electrician, factory machinist, ship engineer, or steam-works mechanic.

STUDY | TINKER | WRECK

UNDERWORLD

- **CONVICT**

You've spent most of your life in and out of prison (probably at Ironhook) and have established a reputation among the guards and inmates.

CONSORT | COMMAND | SKIRMISH
- **CULTIST**

You served a cult dedicated to one of the hundred forgotten gods of the world, participating in arcane rituals, recruiting new members, and battling rival cultists and their false beliefs.

ATTUNE | CONSORT | STUDY
- **DEALER**

You worked in the trade of illicit, contraband, or highly taxed goods—alchemicals, arcane relics, spirit essences, drugs, or weapons.

CONSORT | SWAY | TINKER
- **ENFORCER**

You worked as a thug, armed robber, extortionist, or killer, either on your own or as muscle for an underworld gang. You probably have a grim and intimidating reputation.

COMMAND | SKIRMISH | WRECK
- **FENCE**

You bought and sold stolen goods on the black market, establishing connections throughout the underworld as well as with supposedly upstanding citizens who conducted business with you in secret.

CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
- **HUSTLER**

You made your coin as a con artist, gambler, fake medium, loan shark, or racketeer. You can spot an easy mark a mile away.

CONSORT | STUDY | SWAY
- **INFORMANT**

You played the most dangerous underworld game—spilling valuable secrets to the cops or other gangs, but it's never enough. Some people still owe you and others want to see you pay.

HUNT | STUDY | SURVEY
- **LARK**

You were a sex worker, wise in the ways of seduction—an escort, erotic performer, concubine, brothel companion, or streetwalker.

CONSORT | FINESSE | SWAY
- **ROOF RUNNER**

You were a lookout, scout, and messenger for an underworld gang. The rooftop routes across the city were your playground.

HUNT | PROWL | SURVEY
- **THIEF**

You worked as a burglar, pickpocket, or smash-and-grab runner, providing valuable stolen goods to fences for black market sales.

FINESSE | PROWL | TINKER



CATALYST

THE OTHER

LIVING WORLD

The ghost field touches another living world— a world that comes into contact with the Shattered Isles where the field wears thin. Ironically, the thinnest places¹ are where lightning barriers have operated the longest—especially in Dorskvol, where the original barriers in Charterhall have run uninterrupted for centuries—maintained by Sparkwright students in order to practice their craft.

The Immortal Emperor has used his sorceries to see into this world; witnessing its nations, armies, and machines of war, and believes it is a threat to his supreme authority.

New artillery cannons, war hulls, battleships, and experimental airships are being constructed as fast as possible, to be sent to every location that the Emperor's circle of mystics have divined to be most vulnerable to incursion.

FRACTURES

A **fracture** is a highly charged breach through the ghost field that temporarily connects the Shattered Isles to another living world, allowing people and objects to cross over.

Bright, cerulean light emanates from the fractures when they appear, along with a vaporous mist of buoyant particles that cause people and objects passing through to drift slowly downward. Very few people have witnessed them, and their official study is conducted under strict secrecy.

Some fractures are so massive they can swallow an entire ship, while others are very small and brief, just a few moments of intense light and electricity, only large enough for an individual to pass through.

Fractures have occurred ever since the cataclysm, but they are usually extremely rare. Something is causing them to happen more frequently—possibly the Imperial rail line malfunctions (**page 22**) or something originating in the other world.

1. I highly recommend the *Thin Places Radio* podcast. It's great.

STRANGERS

Strangers are visitors from the other living world, mostly the victims of unexpected fractures rather than intentional excursions. Only a few are in Doskvol—with the exception of Rowan House (see **page 24**).

Recently, a group of Strangers arrived through a fracture over the port, which was explained by the authorities as a routine lightning barrier test. One of the Strangers drowned in the harbor, and the body was recovered by a Docker, who kept their unusual clothes and items, showing them off at a dockside tavern as “mysteries from the deep.” He was last seen being questioned and taken away by a Spirit Warden. The disposition of the drowned Stranger’s ghost is unknown.

Other Strangers arrived in Doskvol by other means, some occult or arcane, some accidental. There are only a few in the city, and they’ve only just begun to become aware of each other. See the Strangers faction on **page 28**.

Has anyone in your game secretly been a Stranger the whole time? Are they seeking out these newly arrived Strangers, or keeping their distance?

THE VANISHED

In addition to the arrival of Strangers from the other world, people have begun to disappear from Doskvol (and other places)—pulled through fractures to the other world.

Have any notable figures suddenly vanished? Is it publicly known? Who is looking into it? Who is trying to cover it up?

Did any of the vanished travel to the other world on purpose? How did they accomplish it, and what evidence did they leave behind?

A good way to hook the players into the situation with the fractures and the other world is to include one (or more) of their friends or contacts among the Vanished. When they visit Sawtooth to get their wounds tended, what if he’s gone? Disappeared into thin air—though a neighbor swears there was a strange light in his rooms and some kind of awful sound shook the walls. The Spirit Wardens even came by and snooped around! What could have happened?

CHARACTERS

- **Major Rowan.** Imperial Military Special Investigator; a “Blackcoat” (*dedicated, skilled, ruthless*). Recently arrived in Doskvol aboard COVENANT (**page 14**). Major Rowan is one of the very few people in the Imperium that knows of the existence of Strangers, and has been deployed by classified Imperial Mandate to capture and question them for the Emperor.

The Major is also an important member of the powerful Rowan family (**page 24**), whose history and destiny is entangled with the other living world.

Where do the Major’s loyalties truly lie—with the official mission or the agenda of Rowan House? Can they be reconciled?

- **Sergeant Lochlan** (*Blades*, p. 267). Senior Bluecoat (*shrewd, tough, commanding*). A Bluecoat patrol picked up a person dressed in odd clothing, confused and rambling about bizarre things, and brought them to Sergeant Lochlan’s precinct headquarters in Crow’s Foot for questioning. She has no way of knowing that this person is a Stranger, and has requested an Inspector to investigate the situation.

Will the other Strangers find this person before Major Rowan does?

- **Director Welker.** Sparkwright Senior Research Scientist, Charterhall University (*brilliant, loyal, proud*). Frequently travels to Cloudspire (**page 38**) on a secret mission to oversee a special team of engineers, unraveling the secrets of pieces of technology that have come through fractures from the other living world.

What artifacts have they found, and how will it impact their research?

- **Inspector Creek** (*perceptive, patient, curious*) & **Constable Avrathi** (*cautious, disciplined, reasonable*). The Inspector has been in Doskvol with the assistant constable for a few months, investigating the theft of Iruvian antiquities from their consulate. In that short time, the Inspector has already heard several stories about unexplained disappearances, lights in the sky, and a confused person wandering the streets, talking about unknown people and places. Despite the lack of orders, the Inspector is looking into these bizarre events.

Will the Inspector’s superiors interfere with this investigation? What happens if Major Rowan finds out? Will Avrathi report on Creek’s negligence of the Iruvian case?

FACTIONS

Several factions are affected by the Strangers and the other world:

- **The Circle of Flame.** Lady Penderyn is among the Vanished.
- **Covenant.** Admiral Bowmore works in secret to rescue the *VERDICT* from the other world. He may recruit a crew to get it done.
- **Ink Rakes.** The existence of Strangers, fractures, and the other world would be the story of the century.
- **Ministry of Preservation.** What will they do when they discover an entire other world of resources to be seized for the Imperium?
- **The Path of Echoes.** Are there spirits in the ghost field that come from the other living world?
- **Prichard Company.** Sometimes a faint remnant of a fracture is caught on film. A photo-lab technician is mapping their locations.
- **Rail Jacks.** If the malfunctioning void gates are the cause of the fractures, what happens if they're repaired?
- **Rowan House.** They will do anything to keep their secret (page 24)—which increasingly frequent fractures threaten to expose.
- **Spirit Wardens.** Deathseeker crows are drawn to fractures in the same way they are drawn to deaths in the city.

THE NATURE OF THE OTHER WORLD

This catalyst provides the means to play a character from a different time and place if you want to. Perhaps they're an occultist or arcane investigator from early industrial-era Earth who discovered a way to navigate fractures or somehow crossed over through the ghost field.

Or, the other world can be a different time period or something wholly of the GM's invention—maybe based on another roleplaying game, book, or film that you love. The important thing is that you create a concept of the other world that suits your group. There's no canonical version.

Here are some possibilities to get you started;

- **1890s to 1920s Earth**—strangely similar to Doskvol in many ways, perhaps with its own occult forces and acolytes. This is one that I prepped for a *Blades* game years ago, when some players really wanted to be occult investigators from Earth that had discovered a portal to another world.

- **A creepy mirror universe** where everyone has a sinister doppelganger, intent on replacing their doubles and infiltrating Dorskvol. Are they evil duplicates or devils in human form? Perhaps the Ministry of Preservation is looking for underworld crews to send across to the mirror world, to act as their agents in plundering its resources for the Imperium. The *Star Trek* episode “Mirror, Mirror” and the *Counterpart* TV series are good inspirations here.
- **A demonic world** where humans serve as agents and soldiers in endless intrigues and wars among power-hungry arch-demons. Maybe the Strangers are escapees from this horrific world, pursued by a demon-spawned hunter—a demonic *Terminator*, maybe?
- **Time travelers** from the ancient world before the cataclysm or perhaps a future era (such as the upcoming supplement *Blades* ’68). Are they traveling on purpose, to prevent (or cause) a calamity, or have they slipped through time due to an accident or the machinations of an other-wordly power?
- **The world beyond the void**—where islands float in a wild blue sky, circling a bright star of blazing quintessence. Some metaphysical scholars have theorized that such a world might have been created during the cataclysm—a bright world of light mirroring the dark world of the Shattered Isles. Something like *Lady Blackbird*, perhaps? <https://johnharper.itch.io/lady-blackbird>

LANGUAGES

To keep things simple, we can imagine that Akorosian is akin to one of the common languages of Earth (or whichever language best suits your other world), so Strangers won’t find it impossible to communicate and adapt to the local tongue. Strict realism isn’t necessary here.

It may even be possible that Akorosian was derived from the language of Strangers that came through fractures in the past—since the Imperium lost almost all of its historical scholarship in the cataclysm, only the Immortal Emperor would know such things for sure.

OPPORTUNITIES

The following pages describe opportunities that arise as a result of the catalyst, organized by crew type. Several of them interconnect and influence others, so you can mix and match them, or run one in the background with an NPC underworld crew.

ASSASSINS

Working through an intermediary to conceal his involvement (perhaps Lydra or Irimina), **Lord Strangford** hires the crew to kidnap **Lynthia Rowan** (who sits on the City Council, **page 24**), interrogate her to gain useful blackmail material against her noble house, or dispose of her entirely.

What Strangford (and everyone outside of Rowan House) doesn't know is that Lynthia is a **Stranger**—a visitor from another world connected to the ghost field. She traveled to Doskvol through the stable fracture beneath Rowan House over 20 years ago, during one of the yearly rituals when the family exchanges its people between worlds. Due to a side effect of the ritual, Lynthia cannot move far from the fracture for more than a few hours, or else she will begin to fade—gradually shifting into the ghost field and ultimately becoming trapped there. From the moment she is abducted, the clock is ticking.

SCORES

- **ASSAULT, DECEPTION, or STEALTH:** Gain access to Rowan House and abduct Lynthia Rowan, or find a way to grab her during one of her brief trips outside.

Interrogate her to discover blackmail secrets for your client. Lynthia is very resistant to threats and will go to extremes to keep quiet, but she is not invulnerable and will make bargains and concessions to protect herself, depending on the crew's approach. She will confess the following (ranked from most to least likely to reveal):

- ▶ Rowan House is conspiring with Bowmore and Clelland House to remove Lord Strangford from the council as well as his position with the leviathan hunters and appoint a new leader who they control.
- ▶ To destroy Strangford, they have allied with Lord Scurlock and an ancient sea demon to sabotage his ships, bedevil his crews, and ruin his leviathan hunts. Rowan House is secretly using the influence and resources of the Church of Ecstasy to hide this heretical and treasonous plot from the Spirit Wardens.
- ▶ Under extreme duress or fear for her life (especially if she begins to fade away), Lynthia will reveal that Rowan House has placed secret agents in every institution of power and is poised to ascend to control the Imperium.

She'll say this largely as a show of force to threaten the crew if they don't release her, but it is a very damning confession that Strangford may be able to use to gather evidence of their plot, if he finds out.

FALLOUT

Depending on the outcome of the kidnapping and interrogation, the crew will likely have a new enemy (either Rowan House or Lord Strangford) and possibly a powerful new ally. A major score like this should be a +2 /-2 status shift, at least.

NPC THREATS

Lynthia Rowan: *Refuses to Talk, Fools You with Convincing Lies, Identifies You, Begins to Fade Away (clock ticks). Unstable Ghost Field Energy Backlash (Lasting harm or Pulled Into the Ghost Field).*

Rowan House Security Team: *Ghost field monitors, ghost echo reinforcements. On Your Tail (clock ticks, below), Cornered, Captured, Severe harm in a fight.*

LOCATION THREATS

Rowan House: *Security measures (Failure to Bypass Masterwork Locks, Recorded by a Monitor Sphere, Alert clock ticks, Alarm Tripped, Spotted, Pursued, Captured, Severe harm in a fight).*

CLOCKS

Lord Strangford is displeased with your work and sells you out or frames you to take the fall (4)



Rowan House security tracks Lynthia to her location (6)



Lynthia fades into the ghost field (6)



Deathseeker crows are drawn to Lynthia and/or where she has been (8)



BRAVOS

Your contact **Lutes**, the tavern owner, comes to the crew with a job. One of his patrons, newly arrived in Doskvol from some far-flung place (with an odd accent and clothes) confided in Lutes that she's on the run—pursued by a pair of bounty hunters from her homeland who wrongly believe she's a criminal to be captured or killed.

It's obvious that Lutes feels some paternal protective instinct for the young woman—who goes by the nickname “**Sparrow**”—and will be happy to pay you (in coin or favors) to attack the bounty hunters and drive them off for good. Lutes has learned from a fellow tavern-keeper that the pair are staying at an inn in Crow's Foot called the Black Stag Inn, and attracted some amount of notice due to their strange way of speaking and unusual outfits (which they've since covered with local garb to blend in better).

Of course, Sparrow and the bounty hunters are **Strangers**—but so is Lutes! He's been in Doskvol for a long time, and Sparrow is the first person from his world that he's encountered. The bounty hunters were sent after Sparrow, but they'll be just as eager to capture Lutes if they discover who he is.

SPARROW & THE BOUNTY HUNTERS

The details of Sparrow and the bounty hunters depends on the nature of the other world, but they should have these features:

- Sparrow is shaken up by her situation, but she's tough and brave. She's brought an important artifact with her from the other world, which is why the bounty hunters were sent after her.
- The hunters work extremely efficiently together, and count in **scale** as a medium gang.
- They each have a unique **weapon** and/or **item** from the other world that gives them a significant advantage in a fight, both offensively and defensively.
- If the fight isn't going their way, the hunters will try to escape and return later to capture Sparrow on their own terms. They're very quick and difficult to pursue.

SCORE

- **ASSAULT:** Go to the Black Stag Inn, beat the hell out of the bounty hunters, and tell them to leave Sparrow alone.

FALLOUT

The Black Stag Inn is on the Crow's turf, and is in fact one of their claims. They don't take kindly to crews showing up without invitation to start fights on their property. The crew can try to talk to them first and maybe get permission, but the threat of the bounty hunters escaping (see the clock below) should definitely be in play during that delay. If the crew doesn't get permission, they'll lose status with the Crows (who'll be another threat to deal with if they become *Hostile*).

Depending on what happens with Sparrow and the bounty hunters, the crew may be recruited to assist Lutes in helping more Strangers, and may find themselves targeted directly by the powers that be in the other world.

NPC THREATS

The Bounty Hunters: *Knocked Out, Severe or Fatal harm, Immobilized, They Escape (or tick the clock, below). On Your Tail, Cornered, Captured.*

The Crows: *Demanding, You're Surrounded, Lasting harm, Captured, Tossed Out of Crow's Foot.*

Bluecoat Patrol: *Break Things Up, Lasting harm, Arrested.*

LOCATION THREATS

The Black Stag Inn: *Patrons (Remember Your Faces, tick Inspector clock below). Bouncer (Decides to Get Involved).*

CLOCKS

The bounty hunters escape (4)



Witnesses tell Inspector Creek about you when he comes around to investigate (6)



Bounty hunters discover Lutes (6)



The local Bluecoat patrol actually bothers to show up to break up the fight (8)



CULT

Every night, the same dream—a strange other world, glimpsed dimly, as if through smoky glass. Figures shift and sway, obscuring then revealing an occult artifact, thrumming with power, droning one of the secret names of your deity in an unknown tongue.

And behold, a crack in the glass that obscures the other world, rimmed with cerulean light—a fracture; a doorway—somewhere here, in Daskvol. You and the rest of the cult share this dream, guiding you to the portal and beyond, to seize that which your deity desires.

SCORES

- **ASSAULT, DECEPTION, SOCIAL, or STEALTH:** Gain control of the site in Daskvol that you've been lead to by your dreams, where the remnant of a fracture remains. *Is it in an ancient temple beneath the city, an abandoned part of Coalridge mines, the occult library of a noble house, deep in the deathlands, or somewhere else?*
- **OCCULT:** Acquire the necessary arcane materials, implements, and/or sacrifices needed and perform the ritual to reopen the fracture and travel to the other world.
- **ASSAULT, DECEPTION, SOCIAL, or STEALTH:** Acquire the occult artifact that your deity desires. Let nothing stand in your way. *Who possesses it in the other world? What are they doing with it? What will they do to keep it?*
- **TRANSPORT:** Bring the artifact back to your lair in Daskvol (or another site that your deity commands), avoiding Spirit Wardens and their patrolling crows, a rival cult (also seeking the artifact), and possibly pursuit from those you stole it from.

FALLOUT

If the cult succeeds, their deity may guide them to other fractures—leading to other artifacts in the other world (or perhaps a series of different worlds?). *What will their deity demand of them once all of the artifacts are assembled?*

If the cult fails, they must seek redemption. *What punishments do they face? What can they do to appease their angered deity? If the rival cult seizes the artifact, what will they unleash?*

NPC THREATS

The People of the Other World: *Suspicious of You, Alert ticks, Alarm Raised, Demanding, Hostile, Cornered, Captured, Severe harm in a fight.*

The Rival Cult: *Follows Your Trail, Ambushes You, Cornered, Captured, Severe harm in a fight or Occult harm from their god.*

The Spirit Wardens: *Crows Circle In (4-clock), On Your Tail, Cornered, Captured, Severe or Deadly harm in combat.*

LOCATION THREATS

The Site of the Fracture: *The Ritual Circle (Arcane Energy Backlash, Disoriented, Seen by Something Beyond the Void). Things Drawn Out of the Darkness by the Ritual (Occult harm, Severe harm in combat, Seized, Carried Away Into Darkness).*

Traversing the Void Between Worlds: *Performing the Ritual (Drained, Lasting harm, Marked, Item Lost or Destroyed). Strange Energies in the Void (You're Changed, Separated, Temporary or Lasting harm).*

The Other World: *An unfamiliar land (Lost, Confused, Separated, Environmental Hazards).*

CLOCKS

The fracture closes before you make it back (6)



The Spirit Wardens find you (6)



Rowan House (or Major Rowan) discovers what you did (8)



You attract the notice of another forgotten god (8)



HAWKERS

A new product—from the other living world—has appeared on the scene, causing a stir among the Hawkers' clientele, and creating a competitive advantage for an enemy or rival operation. Perhaps the product is a drug or other vice substance, or perhaps it's fine art, music (phonograph records?), food, or some other luxury that the rival operation is using to attract clients with its strange novelty.

Use one of the crew's existing rivals in your series, or introduce a new purveyor: **the Branch Twins**.

THE BRANCH TWINS

These siblings operate a high-class house of pleasures in Silkshore, known as the Cloister, either newly opened or recently reopened to provide services to non-exclusive clientele. Their operation is rich and opulent, yet tasteful—the perfect place to attract wealthy connoisseurs who've become bored with the usual fare on offer elsewhere.

Rumor is, the Branch Twins are backed by money from a powerful noble house, possibly the Drakes (**page 82**).

- **LEYELLA BRANCH:** Cool, sophisticated, and aloof. An expert in history, finance, games of strategy, and the dueling arts. The taskmaster of the operation.
- **LAURENT BRANCH:** Charming, handsome, and warm. An expert in occult studies, poetry, music, and the visual arts. The host of the operation.

SCORES

- **DECEPTION, SOCIAL, or STEALTH:** Gain entry to the rival's operation and discover what they're peddling, and perhaps where it's coming from.
- **ANY TYPE:** Acquire the new product for yourselves, and/or make sure your rival loses access to it.

FALLOUT

If the crew successfully acquires the new product from the other world, they might draw the attention of interested parties (Major Rowan, Rowan House, Inspector Creek, the Spirit Wardens, and probably others). Is it worth the Heat?

NPC THREATS

The Branch Twins: *Suspicious of You, See Through Your Lies, Hostile, Observe Your Vulnerabilities in Secret.*

Clientele: *Demanding (wants a free sample), Threatening (they'll go to the cops or a powerful friend), Addicted (follow you, entreat your friends, make empty promises).*

Bluecoats: *Spot Suspicious Activities, Demanding, Hostile, Severe harm in a fight, Arrested.*

Major Rowan: *Collecting Evidence, On Your Tail, Ambushed, Captured, Severe or Deadly harm in combat.*

Inspector Creek: *Collecting Evidence, Surveilling You in Secret, Identifies You.*

LOCATION THREATS

The Cloister: *All manner of exquisite vices (Tempted by Luxurious Pleasures, Distracted, Misdirected or Mislead, Relaxed / Let Your Guard Down). Security staff and systems (Alert clock, Alarm Tripped, Cornered, Thrown Out, Severe harm in a fight).*

CLOCKS

Clients talk about the new product and draw the attention of the authorities (8)



Another rival crew makes a move to get the product (6)



Major Rowan tracks down the product (8)



Someone from the other world tracks down the product and takes steps to recover or destroy it (8)



Extended usage of the product has a strange effect on the clientele, which draws the attention of the deathseeker crows (8)



SHADOWS

Director Welker (page 59), acting through his skillful assistant, **Miss Ketridge**, hires the crew to “acquire” a set of artifacts that were recently smuggled into the city from the deathlands. They’re currently in the possession of **Professor Hadley Rowan** of Doskvol Academy in Whitecrown (a member of **Rowan House**, page 24).

The Academy is known to have exceptional security measures (not to mention its connection to most of the powerful citizens of the city), so Miss Ketridge is authorized to provide a large payment for this service: **20 coin**.

Miss Ketridge emphasizes that it’s extremely important that the operation be carried out with the most minimal amount of exposure for you, her, and her client, or payment will be reduced accordingly. In addition, the artifacts are not to be damaged, nor is the crew allowed to inquire about their origin or purpose.

The “artifacts” comprise the contents of a room that shifted through a fracture from the other living world into the deathlands, as well as the partially mummified corpse of a person who was in the room at the time and perished in the toxic miasma. The details of these items and the corpse depend on the nature of the other living world, but among them is at least one piece of strange technology (either weirdly advanced or arcane in nature), which is Director Welker’s true target. Whatever this object is, it’s the key to understanding his current research at Cloudspire.

SCORES

- **DECEPTION, SOCIAL, or STEALTH:** Gain entry to the Metaphysical Research Wing of Doskvol Academy, access Professor Rowan’s office and lab, grab the artifacts, and escape.
- **SOCIAL** (optional): Meet with other interested parties, who might make an offer. Major Rowan and Inspector Creek are possibilities, if they’ve picked up on any leads regarding the artifact smuggling. The Circle of Flame, the Path of Echoes, Charterhall University, and the Ink Rakes will also be very interested in the strange items, but probably lack the funds to compete with Welker’s offer.

FALLOUT

As soon as the theft is noticed, Professor Rowan will inform Rowan House, who will in turn contact Major Rowan to immediately investigate the situation and discover who stole the items and where they ended up. Start by ticking the Major's clock (bottom of this page) equal to the amount of Heat generated by the score.

NPC THREATS

Miss Ketridge: *Suspicious of Deception or Trickery, Sees Through Your Lies, Disappointed in You (-1 status).*

Major Rowan: *Collecting Evidence, On Your Tail, Ambushed, Captured, Severe or Deadly harm in combat.*

Military Reinforcements: *Surrounded, Overwhelming Force or Deadly harm.*

LOCATION THREATS

Whitecrown: Bluecoat harbor patrol boats. Private security forces—mounted patrols, security hulls, monitor spheres (**page 10**), security checkpoints. (*Spotted, Recorded by a Monitor Sphere, Identified, Detained, Arrested, Severe harm in combat*).

Doskvol Academy: Security systems (*Failure to Bypass Masterwork Locks, Recorded by a Monitor Sphere, Alert clock ticks, Alarm Tripped, Pursued, Captured, Severe harm in a fight*).

Metaphysical Research Lab: Dangerous artifacts and unstable experiments in progress (*Arcane Energy harm, Immobilized, Entranced, Drained, Temporarily Blinded, Items Turn to Dust*).

CLOCKS

Academy security is alerted (6)



Prolonged proximity to the artifacts marks you with arcane energies that attract deathseeker crows (6)



Major Rowan tracks you down (8)



SMUGGLERS

One of your contacts arranges a meeting with **Lady Thorn** of the Deathlands Scavengers (*Blades*, p. 288). Her people have found something special beyond the lightning barriers—a collection of odd items along with a corpse, seemingly from some strange place or time. Lady Thorn has promised to deliver these items (and the body) to **Professor Hadley Rowan** of Dorskvol Academy (and **Rowan House**, page 24) in exchange for a handsome reward. And that's where you come in—everything must be smuggled back into the city somehow, and then brought past the checkpoints and patrols of Whitecrown to the professor's research offices at the school.

The details of the items and the corpse depend on the nature of the other living world, but they are essentially the contents of a room, along with its furnishings and inhabitant, who was pulled through a fracture into the deathlands and expired soon after. Perhaps there are books, works of art (phonograph records?), documents and newspapers, bits of technology, fashion items, etc. All somewhat (or very) odd and seemingly not of this world.

SCORES

- **TRANSPORT:** Travel to the site of the fracture in the deathlands, evade or overcome the horrors that congregate there, grab all the items and the corpse, and make it back into the city. *If the Smugglers use a boat, the site can be accessible by water, perhaps an offshoot of the Dorsk river, or a shore along the coast of the Void Sea.*
- **SOCIAL** (optional): Meet with other potential buyers. Major Rowan, Inspector Creek, and Director Welker's assistant, Miss Ketridge, are all interested parties, though the crew may want to avoid attention from authorities. The Circle of Flame, the Path of Echoes, Charterhall University, and the Ink Rakes will also be very interested in the strange haul.
- **TRANSPORT:** Smuggle the items to the buyer's location.

FALLOUT

If Rowan House discovers that the crew knows anything about the other living world, they will target them for capture, questioning, and perhaps termination, depending on the crew's Tier, status, reputation, and how they handle the situation.

If the scores go well, the crew might find themselves enlisted to continue smuggling items from the other world, assuming a way can be found to do it consistently.

NPC THREATS

Major Rowan: *Collecting Evidence, On Your Tail, Ambushed, Captured, Severe or Deadly harm in combat.*

Military Reinforcements: *Surrounded, Overwhelming Force or Deadly harm.*

Rival Scavengers: *Spotted, Hunted, Captured, Driven Off, harmed. Unwilling to Bargain.*

Inspector Creek: *Collecting Evidence, Surveilling You in Secret, Identifies You.*

LOCATION THREATS

Lightning Barriers: Security checkpoints (*Spotted, Questioned, Turned Away, Detained*). Electrocuting hazards (*Damaged Gear or Vehicle, Severe harm*).

The Deathlands: Obscuring, toxic miasmas (*Lost, Separated, Temporary or Lasting harm*). A horror (*Blades*, p. 252) or wandering group of savage spirits. Rival Deathlands Scavengers (*Spotted, Hunted, Captured, Driven Off, harmed*).

Whitecrown & Doskvol Academy: Bluecoat harbor patrol boats. Private security forces; mounted patrols, security hulls, monitor spheres (**page 10**), security checkpoints (*Spotted, Recorded by a Monitor Sphere, Identified, Detained, Arrested, Severe harm in combat*).

CLOCKS

Rowan House discovers what you've done (8)



Major Rowan tracks you down (8)



A rival or enemy discovers your operation (6)



Inspector Creek summons you for questioning (8)



PART TWO
SYSTEMS

HARM

This module makes harm more flexible and impactful and provides a new way to earn xp.

When your character suffers harm, record it on your playbook according to its level:

HARM LEVELS

1	Temporary Condition: A negative effect that goes away naturally over time and doesn't require treatment for recovery. <i>Bloodied, Confused, Distracted, Intimidated, Exposed, Seduced, Stunned, Tired, Terrified, Weakened.</i>
2	Lasting harm: Serious injuries, ailments, or impairments. <i>Beaten Up, Blasted, Broken Arm, Burned, Knocked Out, Concussion, Electrocuted, Slashed, Stabbed, Shot in the Leg.</i>
3	Severe harm: Major wounds that can incapacitate a character or even threaten to become fatal if not treated. <i>Bleeding Out, Cursed, Broken Ribs, Deep Stab Wound, Poisoned, Cracked Skull, Shot in the Chest.</i>
4	Fatal harm: A mortal wound or instant death, depending on the situation. <i>Shot in the Head, Stabbed in the Heart, Disintegrated, Drowned in the Void Sea.</i>

You have space on your playbook to record two instances of level 2 harm, one instance of level 3 harm, and one instance of level 4 harm. If you suffer harm at a level that has all instances filled, the harm advances to the next highest level of severity.

You may have an unlimited number of level 1 harm conditions, but if you suffer the same condition a second time, bump it up to level 2—for example, if you're *Winded* and you become *Winded* again, erase it and take level 2 harm *Tired* instead. When you do this, the harm never advances to level 3, even if your level 2 instances are filled.

INVOKING HARM

Harm levels aren't tied to specific mechanical penalties. Instead, harm may be **invoked** by the GM to impede the character, creating a problem or limitation for them. When you invoke harm as the GM, choose one:

- Introduce a **bad outcome** or **new problem** for the character.
- Reduce an **action** and/or **attribute rating** for a roll.
- Reduce the character's **position** or **effect**.

When your character's harm is invoked, you **mark xp**. Feel free to remind the GM of your character's harm when you think it might apply to a situation.

Joséphine's character, Juliette, suffers level 3 severe harm: "Broken Ribs" when a Sparkwright bomb explodes and hurls her out a window. The GM invokes her harm to introduce a bad outcome: Juliette is too injured to flee the scene without assistance. She'll have to get some help or talk her way out of this one. Joséphine marks xp.

Ross's character, Ekeprag Wodi, suffers a level 1 harm condition: "Enthralled" while Consorting in a house of pleasure. The GM invokes this harm to create a problem: Ekeprag is too engaged in their dalliances to notice one of the hosts slipping away to inform on the crew. Ross marks xp.

Abu's character, Valkos, suffers level 2 harm: "Concussion" during a tough brawl with the Billhooks. When the Bluecoats show up to break up the gangs, another fight erupts. The GM invokes Valkos's harm to reduce his Prowess and associated action ratings by 1 during the fight. Abu marks xp.

TOUGH IT OUT

If you think the consequence from an invocation of harm is too punishing or is just something you don't want to deal with in the game, suggest an alternative impediment and discuss it with the GM or just **tough it out**: take **1 Stress per level of the harm** and draw a line through it. You still have the harm and need to recover from it, but it can't be invoked to impede you.

REMOVING LEVEL 1 HARM

Level 1 harm represents temporary negative conditions that can impede your character. Things like *Stunned*, *Tired*, or *Bloodied*.

Some level 1 harm conditions might require an action to remove. For instance, if you're *Tired*, you need to take some time to rest to remove that harm. If you're *Bloodied*, you need to bandage your wounds.

Other types of level 1 harm are removed when it makes sense in the fiction. If you're *Intimidated* by Bazso Baz, how long does that last? Was is a one-time thing, or does it stick with you for a while? That's for the player to decide, based on how they portray their character.

Level 1 harm conditions aren't meant to last forever, though. After being invoked a couple times, or when **downtime** begins, remove your level 1 harm.

SURVIVING FATAL HARM

If you suffer a mortal wound that isn't instantly lethal, you may survive if someone can treat the wound and stabilize you within a few minutes. The fatal harm remains on your playbook and must be dealt with during a **recovery** activity. Also record a **scar**—a permanent injury—like a limp, chronic pain, loss of an eye, etc. You may invoke a scar to impede your character and **mark xp**, as if it were harm.

SYSTEM CHANGES

SPECIAL ABILITIES

- **VIGOROUS** becomes **LIKE HARDENED STEEL**: Permanently fill one segment of your healing clock. When you fight unarmed, your body is a **fine** weapon.
- **TOUGH AS NAILS**: You gain a second space to record level 3 harm. When you suffer a mortal wound, you may mark **3 Stress** to stabilize it and stay alive.

CREW

- **ANOINTED**: Choose a type of supernatural being: ghost, vampire, or demon—you now bear a ritual tattoo of warding against them. When you suffer harm from a creature of that type, reduce its level by one.

TRAUMA

This module makes the immediate consequence of trauma less severe and provides a different way to earn xp.

When you need to mark Stress, but all your boxes are marked, gain a **trauma condition** for your character, mark one of your trauma boxes, then remove all of your Stress. Circle a condition from the list on your playbook (like Cold, Haunted, etc.) or create one of your own.

Describe your character's trauma reaction in the current circumstance, based on the condition that you just chose. You decide how intense this reaction is, and if it causes a problem for your character.

During a brutal melee with the Red Sashes, Sean's character, Arcy Keel, overflows her Stress track and marks a new trauma: Cold. Sean describes Arcy's reaction in the moment—rather than helping an injured ally (Bazso Baz of the Lampblacks), Arcy leaves him behind to his fate in the hands of the enemy. “You’re not my problem anymore,” she says.

INVOKING TRAUMA

Each of your characters' trauma conditions can be invoked once per session to create a problem or complication for them. When you do this, **mark xp**.

This replaces the end-of-session xp award for trauma. Only the player may invoke their character's trauma, not the GM or other players.

Since Sean created a problem when he invoked Arcy's trauma—abandoning a valued ally to death or capture—he marks xp.

RECOVERY & RETIREMENT

Trauma doesn't have to be permanent. Work with the GM to create a long-term project (or other method) to remove one of your conditions and clear a trauma box. Each character's trauma is personal, and the path to recovery should be, too.

When you mark your fourth trauma box, your character can't live the punishing life of a scoundrel. You can either retire them and make a new character or fully focus on recovering from their trauma before they return to life in the underworld.

LOAD

This module changes how items are chosen before and during the score.

Before the score, when you choose your plan for the operation, also choose your character's **load** style: **conspicuous** or **discreet**.

- **CONSPICUOUS:** You have **6 boxes** of items available. You may bring **heavy** items (any item that requires 2 or more boxes of load), but you must choose and mark heavy items before the score. When you're carrying heavy items, you're slower, less agile, and can't swim.
- **DISCREET:** You have **4 boxes** of items available. You may not bring any **heavy** items. You don't have to choose any items before the score.

ADDING LOAD DURING THE SCORE

If your scoundrel picks something up during a score, you count it as a marked load box. If you mark a fifth box, your character becomes conspicuous—even if they were discreet when the score began.

If you mark a seventh box, your character becomes encumbered, and can no longer climb, run, or swim unless they drop enough items to get below 7 load. You can't carry more than 9 boxes' worth of load.

During the score, Valkos finds a stash of coin hidden in the Billhook's lair. Each coin of cash counts as one load, so Abu marks a box on Valkos's sheet. This takes him to 5 boxes, so Valkos is now conspicuous—he'll draw attention when people see him.

SYSTEM CHANGES

CREW

- **RIGGING:** Carry 2 free load of a particular class of item, including a **heavy** item while your load is discreet, if you wish.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

- **MULE:** Your load limits are higher. Conspicuous: 8. Discreet: 6. You're encumbered at 9 boxes of load and can carry a maximum of 10 load. Carrying heavy items doesn't affect your speed or agility.

ADVANCEMENT

This module slows the overall rate of player character and crew advancement.

ADVANCEMENT CLOCKS

Instead of using the current xp trackers on your playbook, draw a set of four **6-segment advancement clocks**. Do the same on the crew sheet. Whenever you would mark xp, tick an advancement clock instead.

To acquire an advancement, fill a number of advancement clocks as detailed below. When you gain the advancement, clear those clocks.

If all your clocks are filled, and you need to mark xp, just make an additional clock to track it. “Extra” xp isn’t lost.

	CLOCKS
New special ability from your playbook or crew sheet	2
Veteran special ability	3
Crew upgrade (per box) ¹	1
Action or attribute dot (see below)	1-4

To add an action or attribute dot, you need a number of filled advancement clocks equal to the new rating. In the example at right, a player adds a dot to **PROWL**, which raises its rating to 2—so it will cost two advancement clocks to acquire.

PROWESS									
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	FINESSE
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	PROWL
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	SKIRMISH
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	WRECK

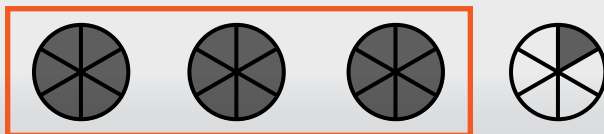
RESOLVE									
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	ATTUNE
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	COMMAND
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	CONSORT
●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	SWAY

Another player wants to add a dot to **SWAY**, which raises their **RESOLVE** attribute to 2, so they clear two of their full advancement clocks and increase their **SWAY** rating.

1. If you use the downtime module (page 86), only cohorts cost xp advances. The other crew upgrades cost coin instead.



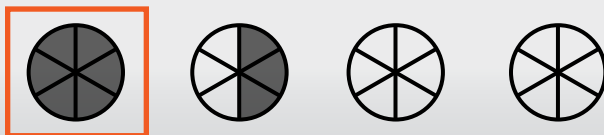
At the start of the session, Joséphine had two full advancement clocks from previous play. During the game, she makes two desperate rolls (2 xp) and then gets 1 xp for problems from her character's trauma and 1 xp for embodying her Whisper xp trigger, for a total of 4 xp. Her third advancement clock is almost full—when it is, she can clear the clocks and get a veteran special ability she wants from the Hound playbook.



PROWESS

●	●	●	FINESSE
●	●	●	PROWL
●	●	●	SKIRMISH
●	●	●	WRECK

Ross decides to add a dot in Finesse, which advances his Prowess attribute to 3, so it costs three full clocks.



The crew playbook has a full advancement clock, so the players decide to clear it and take a new upgrade for their Shadows. They pick **Quality** gear, upgrading the effectiveness of all their burglary and climbing gear.

If they had two full clocks instead, they could expend both advancement clocks to acquire a new **cohort**, since one cohort counts as two upgrade boxes.

DOWNTIME

This module makes downtime activities diceless and changes several details of how they work.

CREW PHASE

First, each **cohort** heals one level of harm. Then resolve **Payoff & Claims, Fallout, Entanglements, Development, and Hold**.

PAYOFF & CLAIMS

Payoff for a score varies based on the details of the operation and/or negotiation with a client. Use the following guidelines as a baseline.

6 coin for a standard score	+4 (or more) for a wealthy target or valuable loot/product
+2 to +8 for more daring or dangerous scores	+1 to +4 for a bonus objective or special request from a client

Also collect downtime payments from **crew claims** (like a vice den).

TITHE

If you're Tier 2 or lower, pay a tithe to your ward boss equal to **1 coin for every 4 coin** from payoff and crew claims. If you can't or won't pay, ask the GM if you can go into **debt** (page 88) or do a favor instead.

BANKS

In addition to your **vaults**, your crew may deposit coin in a **bank**. When your crew has **Wanted Levels**, you lose access to bank funds until you have no Wanted Levels (or find a way to gain illicit access).

EXAMPLE BANKS

- **Mardin Gull**, proprietor of the Leaky Bucket tavern in Tangletown, runs a secret bank (out of reach of the authorities), which you may use as long as you're on good terms.
- **Saltford's**. An impregnable stone fortress at the docks; the oldest private bank in Doskvol. Chief banker Rosella Drake follows her family's tradition of working with the underworld, allowing Wanted crews to access their funds—for the small fee of 1 coin per Wanted Level.

FALLOUT

The GM assesses the fallout from the score in the form of faction **status** changes, the amount of **Heat** gained, and **Rep** earned.

STATUS

+1	The score significantly helped the faction.
+2	The score was a major boon for the faction.
-1	The score hurt the faction.
-2	The score was a major problem for the faction.
-3	Set status to -3 if the crew initiated war with a faction.

HEAT

BASE	0 for quiet, low exposure or 2 for a standard score. +1 Heat per crew Tier.
TARGET	+1 to +4 for a high profile or well-connected target.
CHAOS	+1 for open combat. +2 for destruction or mayhem. +2 if you're at war with another faction.
DEATH	+4 if death occurred in connection to the score.
EVIDENCE	+1 to +4 for witnesses willing to talk or evidence left behind (depending on the quality and/or amount).
REDUCE	Ask the players if they want to ask an appropriate contact or faction to reduce Heat before applying it to the crew sheet. The more powerful or connected they are, the more they can reduce (-1 to -4 Heat). Friendly connections may do this for a few coin (1 per Heat), as a favor , or in exchange for a service . Other connections expect more in return (2 coin per Heat or a significant service).

REP

BASE	1 Rep , +1 per Tier of the target above the crew's Tier.
INFAMY	+1 Rep for every 3 Heat gained for the score (after reduction). +1 Rep per current Wanted Level .

ENTANGLEMENTS

If the crew's **Heat** is 6+, or when the fiction demands, the GM brings an **entanglement** into play. When the crew gains a **Wanted Level**, mark 2 crew xp and pick **Bluecoats** (below).

THE AUTHORITIES

BLUECOATS assail your crew with a severity according to your **Wanted Level** (adjusted down by your positive faction **status** with the Bluecoats).

- 4 Arrest of the whole crew, destruction/seizure of lair and all assets, or the threat of lethal force if you resist them.
- 3 An arrest, destruction/seizure of assets (three or more crew upgrades, emptying your vaults), or the threat of severe beatings (harm 3) if you resist them.
- 2 Interrogation, destruction/seizure of assets (one or two crew upgrades), or the threat of serious beatings (harm 2) if you resist them.
- 1 Demands for favors or coin, observation/tailing of the crew, or the threat of beatings (harm 1) if you resist them.
- 0 Questioning, harassment, threats, observation/tailing.

*To avoid this entanglement, Bluecoats can be bought off for **coin** equal to your **Wanted Level** +4.*

UNDER THEIR THUMB: An authority (Bluecoats, Spirit Wardens, Ministry agents, noble house, etc.) forces you to do their dirty work, simply because they can.

Do what they demand (probably a score that favors them) or face reprisals ("Bluecoats" entanglement, above, as if your **Wanted Level** was 1 higher, and they can't be bought off).

THE USUAL SUSPECTS: The Bluecoats pick up one of your connections, contacts, or vice purveyors to question them.

Make a **fortune roll** based on their resilience and loyalty to see how they hold up. The crew suffers 5 **Heat** minus the highest die.

THE UNDERWORLD

FAVOR: A positive status faction asks you to do something for them. Agree to do it or lose **1 status** with them. The maximum scope of the favor depends on the level of status (see below), but a faction might ask for a lower-level favor if that's all they need.

- +3 A major favor, involving a massive loan of coin or danger, hardship, and effort—probably a score (or more).
- +2 A serious favor, involving a large loan of coin or some danger and effort—possibly a score.
- +1 A moderate favor, involving a small loan of coin or some effort and trouble.

FLIPPED: One of the PC's **rivals** or an enemy convinces one of your clients, contacts, or patrons to switch allegiances. Remove them as an ally until you get that worked out.

RASCALS: A **cohort** or **contact** causes problems for you. Smooth things over with the aggrieved party or lose **status** with their faction.

SHOW OF FORCE: A **negative status** faction moves against you. Make them an offer to back off (**coin** or a **claim**) or go to **war**.

STRANGE FORCES

DEVILRY: A **spirit** or other supernatural trouble is drawn in by the crew's actions—perhaps a past victim, a demon, or a cult?

REMOVING WANTED LEVELS WITH COIN

In addition to removing Wanted Levels with prison time (as in standard *Blades*, p. 148), you can also use **bribery**. For example:

If you know a crooked official (a Magistrate, City Councilor, Bluecoat Commander, etc.), you may offer a bribe to remove a **Wanted Level**—usually by paying **coin** equal to your (**Tier + Wanted Level**) x 6, or by doing a *significant* favor for the official—probably involving a score.

DEVELOPMENT

Instead of spending a lump sum of **coin** to rise in **Tier**, you invest in **crew upgrades** over time to improve.

These crew upgrades cost coin instead of crew advances:

UPGRADE	COIN
Camouflage, Rigging, or Underground Maps & Passkeys.	6
Composed, Hardened, Ordained, or Steady (per box). Ironhook Contacts, Ritual Sanctum.	8
Barge, Lair Upgrade, Quality, or Training. Mastery (per box). Elite (cohort type).	10

If you want slower crew development, increase the costs (to 10/12/14, or even doubled to 12/16/20—whatever suits your preferred pace).

Cohorts don't cost coin, they cost **two crew advancement clocks** (if the advancement module is used) or **one crew advance** (if standard Blades advancement is used).

*The Bloodletters decide to upgrade their lair by getting **Hidden**. They move into the cellar of an abandoned distillery in Six Towers and now the Bluecoats won't come knocking on their door every time they round up the usual suspects. This costs 10 coin. For the next upgrade, they decide that **Hawkers Rigging** will come in handy, so they pay 6 coin for that.*

*Later on, they add a **cohort** to the crew: an expert physicker on call to treat their wounds. This requires two advancement clocks.*

TIER ADVANCEMENT

To advance your crew's Tier, you need to meet three requirements:

- Your **Rep track** is full (including any reduction from **turf**).
- You have **strong hold** on your current Tier. (See "Hold" on the following page.)
- You possess the required number of **upgrades** and **cohorts** to advance. (See the requirements on the next page.)

When you meet the requirements, advance to the next Tier and clear your Rep tracker.

TIER ADVANCEMENT REQUIREMENTS

0 → 1	Possess 6 crew upgrades and at least 2 cohorts.
1 → 2	Possess 8 crew upgrades and at least 4 cohorts.
2 → 3	Possess 12 crew upgrades and at least 6 cohorts.
3 → 4	Possess 20 crew upgrades and at least 8 cohorts.

INCREASE FACTION STATUS

You may also spend coin to develop your **status** with a faction you're not at war with. To improve your status by 1, spend **6 coin per Tier** of the faction. You may improve your status up to +2 with this method, but to get to +3 status, you'll have to earn it through your actions.

The Remnant want to patch things up with the Ink Rakes, who they've mistreated a bit in the past. To improve their faction status from -1 to 0, they need to pay 12 coin since the Ink Rakes are Tier 2. A hefty sum, but at least the journalists won't keep dragging the Remnant's name through the mud every chance they get.

If you're at war with a faction (status -3), you might be able to negotiate an end to hostilities and improvement in status by offering coin, but they'll likely demand even more coin and other concessions in that case.

HOLD

Your crew's **hold** on their Tier is measured by your number of **turf claims**. To have **strong hold** on your Tier, you must have a number of turf claims equal to or greater than your Tier. While your number of turf claims is lower than your Tier, your hold is **weak**. When you're at war with another faction (*Blades*, p. 46) your hold is reduced by one, so a strong hold becomes weak and a weak hold is lost, dropping your Tier by one until you regain your hold again.

When a crew's hold is weak, the "Show of Force" entanglement is a good one to introduce, as well as "Rascals" if the crew's cohorts are the type to lash out when they think things are going poorly for the crew.

SCOUNDREL PHASE

At the beginning of the scoundrel phase, for each character:

- Restore your **Armor** and **Special Armor**.
- Remove all **level 1 harm**. If you have a safe place to rest, add **one tick** to your **healing clock**.

The rest of downtime consists of **vice** and **activities** (vice does not count as an activity). Each player can do these in any order. Each pursuit includes a **question** or two to prompt roleplaying.

VICE

When you indulge your vice, spend **1 coin** and clear all of your **Stress**. If your Stress level was **6 or more**, you **overindulge**—your character suffers a complication depending on your roll on the following table:

1	Get Wild: Damage property; terrify citizens. Make amends or lose 1 status with the faction or citizenry.
2	Big Spender: You indulge lavishly; spend +1 coin .
3	Brag or accidentally talk about your exploits. +1 Heat .
4	Attract Trouble: Face an entanglement .
5	Tapped: Your purveyor cuts you off. Find a new one.
6	Wasted: Your vice costs a downtime activity.

Instead of overindulgence, you can choose to be **lost** to your vice. Play a different character until this one returns.

What's it like when you indulge? Ask the GM if your purveyor has any rumors, gossip, job offers, opportunities, or warnings for you.

DEBT

You may go into **debt** with a provider if they agree. Note the initial coin you owe, then make a 4-segment clock and tick it every downtime you still owe the debt. If the clock fills, the provider takes steps to get their money back. To remove a tick, pay coin equal to half the initial amount (round up) or do a favor. To resolve your debt, pay the initial amount when you have no ticks on the clock.

ACTIVITIES

There are four scoundrel downtime activities: **Acquire**, **Recover**, **Train**, and **Work**. If you have **level 3** harm or survived a mortal wound, you *must* use at least one of your downtime activities to Recover.

Each scoundrel may pursue two free activities during downtime. Additional activities cost **1 coin** or **1 Rep** each.

ACQUIRE

Gain temporary items, services, vehicles, or cohorts for the crew. Make a **4-segment supply clock** for the acquisition, to be ticked each time it's used in a consequential way.

- Pay **1 coin** for every level of **Quality** higher than the crew's Tier.
- Pay **+1 coin** for a special feature (hidden compartments, disguised or easily concealable, waterproof, etc.).
- If the acquisition is very rare, heavily regulated, restricted, or prohibited, ask the GM how much extra **coin** and/or **Heat** is required to get it, or if you'll need to acquire it with a **score**.

Generally, the whole crew gains access to what's acquired, counting each individual member's usage against the supply clock.

The crew acquires the services of a veteran physicker (Quality 3) to treat them during recovery. Since they're Tier 0, this costs 3 coin. Each time the physicker treats a crew member, they tick the usage clock. After four treatments, the physicker's service ends.

You may acquire a personal item in the same manner, comparing its **Quality** to your **lifestyle** rating.

Where do you go and who do you deal with to acquire what you seek? You can ask the GM if they'll accept a favor instead of coin.

SUPPLY CLOCKS

Supply clocks can be useful for a variety of applications, such as:

- A stockpile of illicit products for a Hawker crew to distribute
- Blackmail secrets obtained by a crew of Shadows
- Favors promised by a friend or ally
- Dwindling provisions used for survival in the deathlands

For a significant expenditure, tick the clock multiple times.

RECOVER

When you recover in a safe location, you gain **ticks** on your **healing clock** equal to your crew's **Tier+1**. When your healing clock fills, reduce each instance of harm you have by one level. When you remove all harm, clear your healing clock.

If you also engage the services of a physicker, they remove an instance of harm with a level equal to or less than their **Quality**. *Physickers on the playbooks (like Sawtooth) are Quality 2*. For each **coin** you pay, increase the Physicker's Quality by one for this downtime, to receive more extensive care.

HOSPITAL

Instead of recovering on your own, use this activity to stay in a private **hospital** (there are no public hospitals in Daskvol). Remove all of your harm and choose: Take **1 Heat** and pay **2 coin** -OR- pay **3 coin**.

■ *When you recover, how are you vulnerable? Do you show the pain of your injuries, open up to someone emotionally, or something else?*

TRAIN

Use this activity to spend **xp** to get an advance for your character. (You don't advance instantly as in standard *Blades*.)

Describe a training montage, then spend **xp** to advance. To advance an action rating to 3, you need to train with an instructor with Quality 3 or more (either **acquired** or from a crew **training upgrade**). Action ratings of 4 aren't available until you unlock Mastery for your crew (which also gives you access to Quality 4 instructors).

Special abilities may require an instructor (Quality 3), depending on their nature—whether an innate talent or something that's learned over time. You can make the call as a group on a case-by-case basis.

You can use this activity to act as an **instructor** with Quality equal to your rating in the relevant action rating being advanced. When you're an instructor, you may also spend **xp** to advance.

■ *What's your relationship with your instructor? Has it changed?
What's the most challenging or valuable part of your training session?*

WORK

Accomplish a **simple project** or work a **side job** to earn **1 coin**. Ask the GM if you can charge more (especially if you work for a wealthy client) or gain some other benefit instead of coin (like earning a favor, reducing **Heat**, etc.).

Note: *Blades* is about scoundrels doing scores, not having regular jobs, so consider limiting side jobs to one per PC during downtime.

For a **long-term project**, make an **8-segment clock**. When you spend an activity working on it, mark a number of ticks equal to your **action rating**. Add **one tick** if you have a **workshop** (or some other type of appropriate advantage). Elaborate projects require multiple clocks (and may also call for a successful score to fully complete).

The crew has risen to Wanted Level 3, and all the while, Scarlet has been working on long-term projects to frame their most hated enemy, Master Slane, and send him away for good. During downtime, she Consorts to plant rumors and finish the final clock in the project. The crew can now pull off a score to break into Slane's office and plant the most damning evidence right before they tip off the Inspector who's been investigating the case.

Who do you do work for? Ask the GM if there's anything going on with them. What challenge do you address on your project?

SYSTEM CHANGES

- A mechanic that gives +1d to reduce Heat rolls instead **lowers Heat by 1** during the Fallout phase (**page 83**).
- +1d to healing rolls instead counts as **one tick** on the **healing clock**.
- A special ability that grants +1 Stress box (like **COMPOSED**) also raises the overindulgence threshold by 1 (from 6 to 7).

SPECIAL ABILITIES

- **CONNECTED:** Make a 6-clock called "Favor." During **downtime**, tick this clock in place of spending **coin** or taking **Heat**, 1-for-1. When the clock fills, one of your friends or allies calls on the crew for help with something. When you help them, clear the clock.
- **FUNCTIONING VICE:** When you indulge with a companion, your **1 coin** expenditure covers their vice cost as well. When you overindulge, instead of a reaction, you may reset to **2 Stress**.

- **VIGOROUS** becomes **LIKE HARDENED STEEL**: Permanently fill one segment of your healing clock. When you fight unarmed, your body is a **fine** weapon.
- **PHYSICKER**: You can **TINKER** with bones, blood, and bodily humours to treat wounds. You can attempt to stabilize someone who just suffered a mortal injury. You may **STUDY** a poison, malady, or corpse. In **downtime**, use the **recover** activity to act as a Physicker for those who recover (including yourself) with **Quality** equal to your **TINKER** rating. *If you have level 3 or 4 harm, you must recover before you use this ability in downtime.*
- **SINISTER GUILF**: You get two free additional downtime activities.

CREWS

- **Training Upgrades**: For **INSIGHT**, **PROWESS**, and **RESOLVE** training upgrades, you gain free access to a Quality 3 **instructor** for all actions under that attribute.

When you gain the **Personal** training upgrade, permanently mark 1 xp in one of your advancement clocks (or in one of your xp tracks in standard *Blades*).

Mastery gives you free access to Quality 4 instructors for any action (and unlocks rating 4 actions).

When you advance with one of these instructors, **mark crew xp**.

- **Vaults** are bigger: the first holds 8 coin, the second holds 12.
- **HARDCASE (Prison Claim)**: Your reputation as a tough inmate gives your crew respect in the underworld. Reduce the cost of each crew upgrade by 1 coin.
- **NO TRACES**: When you take Heat in downtime, reduce the total by 1. When you end downtime with **zero Heat**, take **+1 Rep**.
- **PATRON**: You have a benefactor that helps your crew in downtime by reducing one crew **upgrade** cost by 2 -OR- reducing your **Heat** by 2. *Who is your patron? Why do they help you?*
- **SLIPPERY**: Your effective Wanted Level is one less than its actual value (and may go up to 5). When you suffer an entanglement, reduce any coin, Heat, or Rep cost you pay by one.
- **WAREHOUSES (Claim)**: The crew gains one additional **Acquire** activity in downtime.

ACTION

This module overhauls the action system of the game to make it faster and more flexible by introducing the threat roll, which replaces the action roll, as well as modifying Devil's Bargains, resistance, gathering information, and teamwork.

OVERVIEW

- The **threat roll** is an evolution of the common risky/standard action roll. It emphasizes how the scoundrels avoid the dangers they face during a score, rather than focusing on the success or failure of their actions.

When you make a threat roll, the GM describes a bad consequence that's about to happen and you take action to avoid it. This way, everyone knows the possible outcome before the roll—you don't have to create a new complication because someone rolled a 4/5. The risk/reward is established up front.

To get a **bonus die**, you can suggest an **additional threat** to add to a threat roll. This is similar to how the Devil's Bargain works in standard *Blades*—gaining a bonus by getting into more trouble. After you make the roll, you assign a die result to each threat, so if you roll one good result, you get to choose which one to avoid and which to suffer.

- **Position** and **effect** are assumed to be risky/standard for threat rolls. You only need to evaluate other positions or effect levels as an option in special cases.
- In this module, a **Devil's Bargain** can be made in any situation, not just when a player is making a roll. The GM can offer a player a bargain to achieve a goal by proposing a cost to pay (like coin, Heat, or Stress) or by introducing a threat the scoundrel must face.
- The **push yourself** mechanic and the **resistance roll** are combined in this module. When you push yourself, you make an **attribute** roll and suffer 0-3 Stress, depending on the result. You can do this to reduce the consequences from a threat (even after a roll), increase the effect of an action, or activate a special ability.



THREAT ROLL

When you face a negative **consequence** from a dangerous opponent or challenging situation, make a **threat roll** to see if you can avoid it.

To make a threat roll, roll **1d** for each dot in the **action** you're using, plus any **bonus dice** you have.

Take the highest result to determine what happens.

6	SUCCESS: You avoid the threat.
4/5	PERIL: Suffer a reduced consequence or push yourself to avoid the threat.
1-3	THREAT: You suffer the consequence. If you push yourself , reduce the consequence.

If you're facing multiple threats at once, add **1d** to your pool for every additional threat, then assign a die result to each one.

Oskarr Scurlock is dragging a vengeful ghost into a spirit bottle with his lightning hook. The GM describes two threats:

Electroplasmic energy backlash from the ghost (harm 2) and **Spirit Warden attention** (two ticks on their Alert clock).

Oskarr's player rolls four dice: three for Attune and one more for the additional threat—and gets 6, 4, 4, 2. He assigns the 6 to the energy backlash threat, so he avoids it. He assigns a 4 to the Spirit Wardens threat, so he suffers a reduced consequence (one tick on the clock) or may push himself to avoid it entirely.

ESTABLISHING THE THREAT

To initiate a threat roll, the GM describes a bad **consequence** that's about to happen and you narrate your scoundrel's response.

*"Mylera suddenly draws her blade in the blink of an eye! **She might cut you down before you can react.**"*

"I lunge forward as she draws and try to wrestle her to the floor before she can get her sword out."

If your scoundrel's action initiates the threat, the GM first describes your **effect** and then defines the possible bad **consequence** so you know the risk/reward before you roll.

*“You **sneak into the manor** through the skylight, but you might **draw the attention of the guards** (two ticks on the Alert clock).”*

*“You **search the office to find the hidden files**, but the servants might **catch you in the act**.”*

*“You **disable the complicated spark-craft alarm**, but you might **break your tinkering tools** in the process.”*

*“You **pummel the Bluecoat** and **knock him out**, but during the fight, you might **take a bad hit**, too (harm 2).”*

CHOOSING THE ACTION

Based on your description of your scoundrel's response to the threat, the GM proposes an **action** to use for the roll.

If the proposed action doesn't fit your idea of what your character is doing, describe the scene in more detail to reflect the action rating you intend. If the group can't agree for some reason, the player has the final call on which action rating to roll.

In some special cases, you can use other ratings when you make a threat roll, like an **attribute**, crew **Tier**, or **lifestyle**. See [page 99](#).

ADDITIONAL THREATS

The GM can add additional threats depending on the situation (and the players may suggest them), including threats from the **environment**, **NPC strengths**, or **supernatural** effects.

Additional threats essentially act as bonus dice to your roll. You have to assign a result to them (so you're in more danger), but by adding more dice, you're more likely to avoid any single threat.

If you're facing a really bad consequence, suggest possible additional threats to the GM to increase your dice pool.

*“Ok, I'm just blasting away, firing and reloading as fast as possible... can I add the threat that I **run out of ammo**?”*

*“I really don't want to get possessed by this ghost... can I add the threat that I **suffer harm**—by jumping out the window?”*

GAINING EDGE

When you roll more than one 6 on a threat roll, you gain an **Edge**, which represents the spark of luck or tenacity you get by taking risks.

You can spend the Edge you earn right away to add **greater effect** to your action, or you can carry it forward to use as a **bonus die** on a future roll. If you're in a position to help a **teammate**, you can spend an Edge on their roll. Any remaining Edge you have is lost when downtime starts.

PUSH YOURSELF

When you suffer a consequence, you can choose to **push yourself** to avoid or reduce it (depending on the outcome of the threat roll).

When you push yourself, make a roll using the **attribute** that corresponds to the type of consequence you're suffering, just like a resistance roll in standard *Blades*.

6 6	You take zero Stress .
6	You take 1 Stress .
4/5	You take 2 Stress .
1-3	You take 3 Stress .

If you face multiple consequences, you can push yourself against each one separately.

You can also push yourself to increase the **effect** of an action you take and activate certain **special abilities**, like **NOT TO BE TRIFLED WITH**. When you do this, you may choose to forego the roll and simply take 2 Stress instead.

REDUCED CONSEQUENCE

When a consequence is a numerical cost, like gaining Heat or ticking a clock, reducing the consequence simply means lowering the cost.

More narrative-focused threats require some nuance to interpret when they're reduced, however. This comes with practice, but the effect and consequence examples on **page 101** will help get you started.

*“Okay, reduced effect means the Bluecoats haven’t **captured you** yet... but they do manage to **corner you** in an alley. Do you want to try to fight your way free or do something else?”*

SPECIAL CASES

Most of the time, a standard threat roll is all you need to resolve a dangerous situation. However, there are some special cases that work better with a few tweaks to the mechanic, so they're presented here as options to use when you need them.

CONTROLLED POSITION

If a scoundrel is ever in a position where there's no impending danger, don't call for a threat roll—just describe what they're able to accomplish without taking a risk or paying a cost. If they want to achieve more, they can make a **Devil's Bargain** to do it (see **page 102**).

DESPERATE POSITION

If your scoundrel is outnumbered, outclassed, or badly impaired (perhaps due to harm), they need to make a **desperate** roll to avoid the threat. A desperate roll is all-or-nothing: a 6 is a success, but a 5 or less is a threat result—you suffer the consequence.

6	SUCCESS: You avoid the threat.
1-5	THREAT: You suffer the consequence. If you push yourself , reduce the consequence.

When you make a desperate threat roll, mark xp.

The GM can call for a desperate roll to indicate that a threat is more serious, beyond the usual dangers a scoundrel faces. Fighting a gang enforcer is risky, but if you're jumped by three of them at once, things are desperate. Sneaking past the bouncer at the Leaky Bucket is risky, but the security at the Centurialia Club is in a whole different league.

Fictional positioning and character abilities can mitigate desperate threats. If a scoundrel has a rifle and time to fire and reload before the three enforcers can reach them, or if they're **NOT TO BE TRIFLED WITH**, for example, facing three enemies at once wouldn't be desperate—it's a standard threat roll in that case.

When you call for a desperate roll, ask the player if they want to carry on with their course of action or try a different way (if possible). A clever flashback, cunning maneuver, or help from a teammate might be enough to improve their position.

USING AN ATTRIBUTE

Sometimes it makes sense to use a scoundrel's **attribute rating** for a threat roll. This works well when a character is trying to avoid a threat resulting from their own potential weaknesses.

- Roll **INSIGHT** against threats involving disorientation, confusion, doubt, or uncertainty.
- Roll **PROWESS** against threats resulting from pushing physical limits (strength, speed, endurance), exhaustion, or deprivations.
- Roll **RESOLVE** against threats involving temptation, lack of self-control, willpower, hesitation, or loss of nerve.

“When Bazso stares me down, I hesitate. I might be too intimidated to stand up to him. I want to roll Resolve and see what happens.”

USING OTHER RATINGS

You can use other ratings with a threat roll as well, like the crew's **Tier** when their clout or reputation is threatened, or a scoundrel's **lifestyle rating** when their affluence or apparent wealth is key to avoiding a threat. Feel free to get creative when the situation calls for it.

THE THREAT OF FAILURE

A threat roll usually resolves the consequence of a threat; it doesn't bear on the effect of your scoundrel's own action. However, sometimes the success of an action seems unlikely or especially difficult. In this case, the GM can introduce the threat of **failure**.

If you assign a 4/5 to a failure threat, your character's action has reduced effect or otherwise doesn't go as you hoped. On a 1-3, the action fails. You can push yourself to improve the outcome, as usual.

*“This is a long sniper shot, so the threat is failure. **You might miss!** And you're not a trained sharpshooter, so it's a desperate roll, too.”*

“Damn, I got a 4. That means I miss, right? Okay, if I push myself to reduce the consequence, what happens?”

“Let's say that you manage to land a shot, but not as well as you hoped—you hit him in the arm, not the chest.”

If you want the threat roll to feel more like the action roll in standard *Blades*, add the threat of failure in addition to the threat at hand. Some players really enjoy having to choose whether their scoundrel succeeds or avoids danger when they get a mixed roll.

EFFECTS & CONSEQUENCES

Effects and consequences are categorized into four levels of impact: **limited**, **standard**, **great**, and **extreme**. Harm levels, for example, are an easy way to show this concept—limited effect is level 1 harm, standard effect is level 2 harm, great effect is level 3 harm, and extreme effect is level 4 harm (fatal).

Any kind of effect or consequence can be conceived this way, not just numerical ones. When the Bluecoats are closing in, how intense is it? Are they still **searching** for the scoundrels (limited), or are they **pursuing** them (standard)? Do the cops have them **cornered** (great), or are the scoundrels actually getting **captured** (extreme)?

A table of example effects and consequences of all kinds, organized by level, is provided on the next page.

*The crew is negotiating for turf with the Billhooks, who are higher Tier and more respected, so the threat is great: they might be **unreasonable** in the bargain (see the last row of the examples).*

*If the effect is reduced, the GM could choose **demanding** (standard effect) instead of unreasonable. The Billhooks insist on a trade that favors them a bit, but nothing beyond reason.*

Opponents who are closely matched usually have standard effect. If a typical scoundrel fights a typical Bluecoat, they probably threaten each other with level 2 harm.

In most cases, you can take a bigger risk to have greater effect. The player could say they're going all-in, fighting their hardest to do harm 3 to the Bluecoat, and risking harm 3 in return. They might be able to go the other way—it's just a mild tussle, so they give and take harm 1.

When opponents aren't closely matched, the more dangerous one gets more impact for less risk. An average duelist could face lethal harm from a master swordsman, while threatening superficial cuts in return.

When you describe effects and consequences, say what happens in the fiction before adding on any mechanical elements. When everyone can imagine what's happening, it's easier to assess the levels of impact and understand the risk/reward factors of the situation.

*"You can **get a few good cuts in**, but he might **overpower you and put the manacles on**. Let's say you're doing harm 2 to him and you might become restrained."*

EFFECT & CONSEQUENCE EXAMPLES

LIMITED	STANDARD	GREAT	EXTREME
1 tick	2 ticks	3 ticks	4 ticks
1 Heat	2 Heat	3 Heat	4 Heat
Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3	Harm 4
Minimal	Adequate	Excellent	Superior
Battered	Damaged	Broken	Destroyed
Slight	Substantial	Serious	Prodigious
Winded	Tired	Exhausted	Incapacitated
Impeded	Slowed	Obstructed	Stopped
Searching	Pursued	Cornered	Captured
Alerted	Spotted	Confronted	Identified
Close	Chasing	Eluded	Vanished
Hindered	Strenuous	Need Help	Unable
Stunned	Disoriented	Debilitated	Overwhelmed
Unfocused	Distracted	Fixated	Engrossed
Curious	Intrigued	Hooked	Enthralled
Amicable	Charmed	Admiring	Enamored
Unsure	Suspicious	Unconvinced	Hostile
Uncertain	Confused	Perplexed	Lost
Rattled	Disrupted	Overcome	Defeated
Hesitant	Intimidated	Afraid	Dominated
Reluctant	Stalling	Unwilling	Opposed
Irritating	Demanding	Unreasonable	Adamant

DEVIL'S BARGAIN

When a scoundrel wants something, and they can't simply achieve it, offer them a **Devil's Bargain** to get it by telling them either:

- The **cost** to get what they want
- A **threat** they need to face

COSTS

MARK STRESS	SPEND COIN	LOSE ITEM	LOSE REP
TICK A CLOCK	SUFFER HARM	TAKE HEAT	LOSE FACTION STATUS

Offer a cost to skip past troubles without spending a lot of time and attention at the table. They pay the cost, and you move on.

*"Yeah, you can pry the window open and sneak in, simple enough, but there's a bit of noise... I'll **tick the Alert clock**."*

*"You spend all night studying the files and it all makes sense. Take **level 1 harm: 'Exhausted'** and you learn who the secret agent is."*

A cost can be minor (1 Stress, one clock tick) or major (losing faction status) depending on the nature of the scoundrel's goal. If a player doesn't agree to the cost, they can instead ask the GM if they can face a threat or undertake some other course of action to get what they want.

When you offer a Stress cost, you can simply name the number (usually just 1 or 2) or ask the scoundrel to **push themselves** to do it.

THREATS

Offer a threat to increase engagement and attention—leading to a threat roll, pushing, teamwork, etc. If a player doesn't want to face the threat, ask them to revise their action to try things a different way.

*"You can steal the documents from Master Slane's office, but he has good security—you **might get caught in the act**."*

"Maybe I can convince one of his men to snatch them for me?"

*"Yeah, you could Sway or Command one of them, but he might **panic and tell Slane** that you're behind the theft when it's noticed. Or just pay him off with **2 coin** and that'll settle it."*

DURING A THREAT ROLL

If the scoundrel is already facing a threat and making a roll, and they want a better chance of success, they can ask for a Devil's Bargain to add an **additional threat** (page 96), giving them +1d to roll.

Of course, after the roll, the player has to give the Devil their due and assign one of their dice results to the additional threat to see if they suffer that consequence.

This usage of the Devil's Bargain is similar to the system in standard *Blades*. The player gets a bonus die in exchange for additional consequences (though the bad outcome isn't guaranteed in this method).

A player can also ask for greater effect or an additional achievement by making a Devil's Bargain.

"I was hoping that my trance powder bomb could take out everyone in the room at once... can we make a Devil's Bargain?"

*"Sure! Either there's a **cost**: mark two more uses of your bandolier, or I can add a **threat**: you overload the bomb and might get hit with the powder, too."*

THE DEVIL IS WATCHING

This form of the Devil's Bargain, unlike the one in standard *Blades*, can be used at any time in play, not just when a player makes a roll. It's the GM's job to listen for times when a scoundrel's action and goals warrant a cost or lead them into the path of a threat.

Players can also speak for the Devil—suggesting bargains for their own scoundrel or other players' characters, especially in dangerous situations. It can be fun for the players to suggest threats for each other, effectively giving each other bonus dice by raising the stakes.

*"You're using your lightning hook next to tanks of electroplasm, right? Seems dangerous... a **tank might get ruptured and explode!**"*

On the flip side, a player might propose a cost as a Devil's Bargain to quickly resolve something they're less interested in playing out in detail.

"We don't have a ton of time left in the session tonight... can we just say that the Bluecoats hassle us for a bit—we each take 1 Stress—then leave us alone? I'd like to keep focused on the main part of the score and try to wrap it up tonight if possible."

GATHERING INFORMATION

With this module, the act of **gathering information** is folded into the usual procedures of play, rather than having its own mechanic.

When a player wants to know something about the world around their character, tell them what's obvious to them, including what they **know**, what they **intuit**, and what they **suspect** might be true, based on the appropriate aspect of their character, like their playbook, background, heritage, special items, or abilities.

"You're a seasoned Lurk, so you can spot every point of infiltration here. But the upper balcony looks the most promising. There's a walkway along an elevated street where you could drop down and not be seen. Of course, the Count is supposed to have good security, so there's probably really good locks up there, at least."

If there's more to discover, ask them if they want to know more, and what their character does to find out.

Based on their approach and the situation at hand, choose one:

- Offer a **Devil's Bargain**: either a **cost** or a **threat**
- Give them a **lead**
- Ask them to start a **long-term project** to investigate the information

DEVIL'S BARGAIN

COST: Offer a **Devil's Bargain** with a **cost** when they can simply get the information for a price. **Coin**, **Heat**, **Stress**, or ticking a **clock** are good options, depending on the nature of the scoundrel's action.

"Helene at the Silver Stag will tell you whatever you want to know about her guests, for the right price. 2 coin should do it."

"You can beat the tar out of him and he tells you everything, but there are witnesses all around. You'll take 1 Heat."

THREAT: Offer a **Devil's Bargain** with a **threat** when there's risk or danger involved, describing the potential **consequence** they face to get the information.

*"The bank is patrolled by elite guards at all hours. During your visit, you can Survey the place to figure out its security systems, but **the guards might become suspicious** unless you're subtle about it—the threat is **two Alert ticks** before the score even starts."*

If the information is especially protected or concealed, the **threat of failure** may come into play, but use this sparingly. It's usually better for players to make discoveries and use the information to drive the game forward instead of being stalled or confused.

*"You can Attune to perceive echoes of recent events, but the killing happened here years ago. Can Attune be used to reach back that far? I think that's a stretch, but it sounds cool, so let's find out with a roll. There are two threats: **you might not perceive anything clearly** from so long ago (failure), and the strain of trying to look back that far **overwhelms your mind** (harm 2)."*

LEADS

Give the player a **lead** when they're not in a position to gather the information yet, but there's a person, place, or thing in the world that can give them the opportunity.

"You don't know anything about the permits and licenses that you'd need to acquire (or fake) to get started on this scam, but your friend Petra works in the city records archives. She probably knows a lot about that stuff."

LONG-TERM PROJECT

If the information is complex or time-consuming to gather, ask them to start a **long-term project** to study the subject during downtime. There's no cost or threat—it's just a matter of time and access to the appropriate research materials or contacts.

"You start going through the leviathan hunter captain's log books, and quickly realize it's written in code. You can Study it and try to crack the cypher, but you'll need to work on it as a long-term project."

If you don't have the materials or contacts (or want better ones), you might acquire an asset, pay a cost, or face a threat to get them.

"If you can acquire the official port logs at the leviathan hunters harbor, you could compare what's in there to what she's written... that'll give you a bonus tick to the project clock every time you work on it. Same goes if you can get one of her crew members to recount a voyage in detail—but there's a threat there if the crew talks to the captain about it."

TEAMWORK

In this module, teamwork is an application of the Devil's Bargain.

When you're in position to help a teammate, tell the GM what benefit you're hoping for and say what you do to help. The GM has final say on which benefit you get, then they tell you what's required to do it.

BENEFITS	
Improved effect or position	+1d to a roll
Cover for them: they don't have to face a threat	More details or questions when they gather info
Protect them: reduce the severity of a consequence	1 (or more) ticks on a clock
REQUIREMENTS	
None (you simply do it)	Take 1 Stress
Face a threat	Push yourself
Suffer harm	1 (or more) ticks on a clock

You can also help another player by giving them **Edge** (page 97).

GROUP ACTIONS & SCALE

When the group faces the same threat (like everyone sneaking past a guard patrol), each player rolls the same action (like **PROWL** in this case) to see how the consequence manifests for their scoundrel.

If the situation has multiple different threats, the team can split up and tackle them individually to address the problems in a variety of ways, each using whichever action is appropriate to what they're doing.

"Okay, while you Prowl past the sentries, I'll Finesse the boat into position (quietly!) so you can drop down with the loot. Maybe Ruby can Survey the canal and make sure we're clear to escape?"

When a team combines their efforts, they'll usually have more **effect** or a better **position** because of an increase in **scale**. If all four crew members **SKIRMISH** as a team, for instance, they're equal in scale to a Bluecoat squad, so no one faces worse harm (and a desperate position) as they would if fighting alone.

LEADING A TEAM

If you're designated as the team's leader, you can **push yourself** on behalf of anyone who's acting with the team (in addition to the scoundrel pushing themselves). Describe how your leadership helps them reduce or avoid the consequence.

COHORTS & PETS

A cohort or pet can also participate in teamwork, providing a benefit for a cost. Since cohorts and pets can't mark Stress or push themselves, don't choose those requirements in this case. If they need to make a roll, use a dice pool equal to their **Quality** or the **COMMAND** rating of their leader (if they're present).

TEAMWORK EXAMPLES

*"As the spirit begins to possess Arcy, I grab her hands in mine and shout over the howling wind and horrible shrieks of the ghost—'Arcy! Don't lose yourself! I love you!' Can that **improve her position** from desperate to risky?"*

*"Yeah, cool! You'll need to **push yourself** to do it, though."*

*"I take out my second pistol and cock the hammer. 'Let's make a run for it!' I fire both guns as we run for the door. Can I **cover** for Sawtooth so he doesn't get shot while we escape?"*

*"Yeah. Now you're facing two **threats**: the first is severe harm from the Fog Hounds shooting back at you. The second is failure: you might not cover Sawtooth and he comes under fire, too."*

"If I use TEMPEST to summon a big fog bank, can I help everyone who's sneaking in? Maybe give them a controlled position?"

"You can, but I think giving them +1d to their Prowl rolls makes more sense here. It's not like they're invisible, just concealed."

*"When the bomb goes off, I want to dive in front of Oskarr and **protect** him from the blast."*

*"Okay, you can either **just do it** and **suffer the harm** instead of Oskarr, or you can make a threat roll against two **threats**: You might suffer level 3 harm, and Oskarr might suffer level 2 harm."*

SYSTEM CHANGES

- This system combines **push yourself** and **resistance roll** into one roll. Any mechanic in *Blades* that adds 1d to a resistance roll adds 1d to the **push yourself** roll instead.
- A mechanic that adds 1d to an action roll adds 1d to the **threat roll** instead.
- When you mark your **special armor** to push yourself, you don't suffer any Stress, so you don't need to roll.

POSITION AND EFFECT

A player can ask to **trade position for effect**, as usual—in that case, offer them a more costly Devil's Bargain or describe a more dangerous threat in exchange for more effect.

ZERO RATING WITH ADDITIONAL THREATS

If you have **zero rating** in an action, roll 2d and keep the lowest to generate one result, and roll 1d for each additional threat to generate additional results. Then assign one result to each threat.

Ross's character has zero rating in Attune, and is facing two threats. First he rolls 2d6 and keeps the lowest. He rolls 6, 3, so his first result is a 3. Then he rolls 1d for the additional threat and gets a 4. Now he has two results to assign to threats: a 3 and a 4.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

- **AMBUSH** becomes **CONTORTIONIST**: You can twist and fold your body to hide in impossibly small and tight spaces.
- **BODYGUARD**: When you **gather information** to anticipate possible threats in the current situation, you get detailed answers to these questions: *Is anyone here a threat to us? What do they intend to do? What's our best escape route?* When you protect or cover someone, take +1d to your rolls.
- **DAREDEVIL**: You get +1d for **desperate** rolls, but take -1d when you **push yourself** to avoid or reduce the consequence.
- **EXPERTISE**: Choose one of your actions. When you **lead a group** using that action, you and your allies get +1d to **push yourself** rolls.
- **FORESIGHT**: Twice per score, describe how your careful preparations add +1d to a teammate's roll, or invoke a **flashback** without paying Stress.

- **GHOST MIND:** You're always aware of supernatural entities in your presence. When you **gather information** about arcane powers or entities, you get detailed answers to these questions: *What kind of supernatural forces are here? What should I do to avoid / neutralize / control them? If I sense the recent spirit traces of living beings here, what do I see them doing? Can I easily sense who they are and where they went, or are they obscured in some way?*
- **IRON WILL:** You're immune to the terror that some supernatural entities inflict. Add **+1d** when you roll against fear or hesitation.
- **MASTERMIND:** You may expend your **special armor** to protect a teammate, or to **push yourself** when you use logic or strategy.
- **SAVAGE** becomes **FEARSOME ASPECT:** When you intimidate, threaten, or commit violence, you're terrifying. Ask the GM who flees or surrenders, who backs off slowly, and who hesitates.
- **SCOUT:** When you **gather information** to locate a target, you get detailed answers to these questions: *What signs do I find that show where they're going? How can I catch up to them, cut them off, or set up an ambush ahead?* When you hide in a prepared position or use camouflage, add **+1d** to any rolls you make.
- **TRUST IN ME:** When you deceive or influence a target with whom you have an intimate relationship, they're especially vulnerable to you. Also, add **+1d** if you need to make a threat roll against them.

CREWS

- **BLOOD BROTHERS:** When you fight alongside your cohorts in combat, they throw themselves wildly into the fray. Any PC in the battle may avoid harm they suffer by marking it on the cohort instead. Your cohorts get the Thugs type for free.
- **BOUND IN DARKNESS:** When you begin a score, each PC that has not lost favor with your deity gains **1 Edge**. You may transfer **Edge** to another cult member without needing to take any action to help them. By taking **1 Stress**, your whispered message is heard by every cult member.
- **INFORMANTS:** When you work on an investigation **long-term project** in downtime, make **one tick** on the clock.
- **SYNCHRONIZED:** When you execute a coordinated maneuver as a team, any 6s rolled by any team member can be freely distributed to teammates to use on their rolls.

THREATS OF DOSKVOL

Tough, capable people; more dangerous than ordinary citizens. Underworld rogues and experts with particular talents.

A Common Bluecoat	A Seasoned Bluecoat	A Gang Leader
A Bouncer	A Gang Enforcer	A Gondolier
A Cabbie	A Servant Hull	A Security Hull
A Zealous Cultist	A Rail Jack	A Ministry Agent
A Docker	An Imperial Soldier	A Vengeful Spirit
Roustabout	A Subdued Spirit	<i>Cortland</i>
An Apprentice	<i>Bear</i>	<i>Harvale Brogan</i>
Duelist	<i>Bell</i>	<i>Capt. Lannock</i>
A Dangerous Echo	<i>Erin</i>	<i>Sgt. Lochlan</i>
An Ironworks	<i>Flint</i>	<i>Chief Helker</i>
Roughneck	<i>Goldie</i>	<i>Hutch</i>
A Prison Guard	<i>Grull</i>	<i>Hutton</i>
A North Hook Sailor	<i>Havid</i>	<i>Karth Orris</i>
A Street Thug	<i>Henner</i>	<i>Master Krocket</i>
<i>Belle Brogan</i>	<i>Hester Vale</i>	<i>Lyssa</i>
<i>Coran</i>	<i>Irelen</i>	<i>Margette Vale</i>
<i>Derret</i>	<i>Jira</i>	<i>Nessa</i>
<i>Hopper</i>	<i>Levyra</i>	<i>Pickett</i>
<i>Leclure</i>	<i>Loop</i>	<i>Richter</i>
<i>Roslyn</i>	<i>Chief Prichard</i>	<i>Slate</i>
	<i>Sercy</i>	<i>Tarvul</i>
	<i>Vandra</i>	<i>Madame Tesslyn</i>
		<i>Ulf Ironborn</i>

Common citizens aren't included since they're not usually a threat to a scoundrel. A citizen may become a threat in their particular area of expertise, however (like a merchant assessing stolen goods), or if they're connected to a more powerful faction or character.

Scale also matters. A whole squad of Bluecoats against a single scoundrel is a serious threat (and probably a desperate position).

Veterans who've seen it all and learned hard lessons, true masters at the limit of human ability, and powerful superhuman threats.

A Military Hull	A Deathlands Horror	A Primeval Spirit
An Inspector	An Ancient Spirit	A Demon
A Malevolent Spirit	A Spirit Warden	An Elite Spirit
An Acolyte Warden	A Vampire	Warden
An Underworld Boss	<i>Lady Ankhayat</i>	An Elder Vampire
<i>Bazso Baz</i>	<i>Lady Clave</i>	<i>Mordis</i>
<i>Cmdr. Clelland</i>	<i>Lord Dalmore</i>	<i>The Oldest of the</i>
<i>Djera Maha</i>	<i>The Dimmer Sisters</i>	<i>Reconciled</i>
<i>Helene</i>	<i>Preceptor Dunvil</i>	<i>Lord Scurlock</i>
<i>Griggs</i>	<i>Lady Drake</i>	<i>Setarra</i>
<i>Mardin Gull</i>	<i>Eisele</i>	
<i>Capt. Michter</i>	<i>Elstera Avrathi</i>	
<i>Lord Mora</i>	<i>Mylera Klev</i>	
<i>Lady Penderyn</i>	<i>Lord Penderyn</i>	
<i>Elder Rowan</i>	<i>Major Rowan</i>	
<i>Rolan Volaris</i>	<i>The Star</i>	
<i>Seresh</i>	<i>Lord Strangford</i>	
<i>Lady Slane</i>	<i>The Tower</i>	
<i>Master Slane</i>		
<i>Lady Thorn</i>		
<i>Tuhan</i>		
<i>Una Farros</i>		
<i>Capt. Vale</i>		

Characters are ranked by their overall threat level in their areas of expertise and with their assets in play. They are less threatening in other situations. For example, Lord Strangford is an extremely dangerous threat in terms of how influential he is among the factions of Doskvol, but in a fistfight in an alley, he's more like an average scoundrel (at best). If his elite personal security team is with him, however, he's much more challenging to deal with.

PLAYBOOK CHANGES

SCOUNDRELS

CUTTER

- **BODYGUARD:** When you **gather information** to anticipate possible threats in the current situation, you get detailed answers to these questions: *Is anyone here a threat to us? What do they intend to do? What's our best escape route?* When you protect or cover someone, take +1d to your rolls.
- **MULE:** Your load limits are higher. Conspicuous: 8. Discreet: 6. You're encumbered at 9 boxes of load and can carry a maximum of 10 load. Carrying heavy items doesn't affect your speed or agility.
- **SAVAGE** becomes **FEARSOME ASPECT:** When you intimidate, threaten, or commit violence, you're terrifying. Ask the GM who flees or surrenders, who backs off slowly, and who hesitates.
- **VIGOROUS** becomes **LIKE HARDENED STEEL:** Permanently fill one segment of your healing clock. When you fight unarmed, your body is a **fine** weapon.

HOUND

- **SCOUT:** When you **gather information** to locate a target, you get detailed answers to these questions: *What signs do I find that show where they're going? How can I catch up to them, cut them off, or set up an ambush ahead?* When you hide in a prepared position or use camouflage, add +1d to any rolls you make.
- **TOUGH AS NAILS:** You gain a second space to record level 3 harm. When you suffer a mortal wound, you may mark 3 **Stress** to stabilize it and stay alive.

LEECH

- **PHYSICKER:** You can **TINKER** with bones, blood, and bodily humours to treat wounds. You can attempt to stabilize someone who just suffered a mortal injury. You may **STUDY** a poison, malady, or corpse. In **downtime**, use the **recover** activity to act as a Physicker for those who recover (including yourself) with **Quality** equal to your **TINKER** rating. *If you have level 3 or 4 harm, you must recover before you use this ability in downtime.*

LURK

- **AMBUSH** becomes **CONTORTIONIST**: You can twist and fold your body to hide in impossibly small and tight spaces.
- **DAREDEVIL**: You get +1d for **desperate** rolls, but take -1d when you **push yourself** to avoid or reduce the consequence.
- **EXPERTISE**: Choose one of your actions. When you **lead a group** using that action, you and your allies get +1d to **push yourself** rolls.

SLIDE

- **TRUST IN ME**: When you deceive or influence a target with whom you have an intimate relationship, they're especially vulnerable to you. Also, add +1d if you need to make a threat roll against them.

SPIDER

- **CONNECTED**: Make a 6-clock called "Favor." During **downtime**, tick this clock in place of spending **coin** or taking **Heat**, 1-for-1. When the clock fills, one of your friends or allies calls on the crew for help with something. When you help them, clear the clock.
- **FORESIGHT**: Twice per score, describe how your careful preparations add +1d to a teammate's roll, or invoke a **flashback** for zero Stress.
- **FUNCTIONING VICE**: When you indulge with a companion, your 1 **coin** expenditure covers their vice cost as well. When you overindulge, instead of a reaction, you may reset to 2 **Stress**.
- **MASTERMIND**: You may expend your **special armor** to protect a teammate, or to **push yourself** when you use logic or strategy.
- **WEAVING THE WEB**: You gain +1d to any rolls you make when gathering information on a target for a score. You get +1d to the **engagement roll** for that operation.

WHISPER

- **GHOST MIND**: You're always aware of supernatural entities in your presence. When you **gather information** about spirits or the ghost field, you get detailed answers to these questions: *What kind of supernatural forces are here? What should I do to avoid / neutralize / control them? If I sense the recent spirit traces of living beings here, what do I see them doing? Can I easily sense who they are and where they went, or are they obscured in some way?*
- **IRON WILL**: You're immune to the terror that some supernatural entities inflict. Add +1d when you roll against fear or hesitation.

XP TRIGGERS

Since *Deep Cuts* changes how you get xp from trauma (page 78), modified **xp triggers** are included on the playbooks, with this format:

- *You embodied a core nature of your playbook.*
- *You expressed your beliefs, heritage, or background.*
- *You struggled because of your vice or ambitions.*

HULL

- **COMPARTMENTS:** Your items are built into your frame and may recess beneath panels out of sight. Your load limits are 3 higher and you may choose heavy items even with discreet load.
- **ELECTROPLASMIC PROJECTORS:** You may create an electric shock, directed beam, or lightning barrier around your nearby area, all at magnitude 2. **Push yourself** to increase the magnitude.

GHOST

Your **vice** is life essence. To satisfy this need, possess a living victim and consume their spirit energy (this may be an action—risking *electroplasmic backlash*—or a downtime activity). When you do so, clear all of your drain.

- **DISSIPATE:** You can disperse the electroplasmic vapor of your ghostly form in order to slowly pass through solid matter. Take **1 drain** for each additional feature: *you do it instantly rather than slowly—anything that passes through your form becomes dangerously electrified or frozen—you shift fully into the ghost field and vanish.* If you choose to vanish, you remain fully in the ghost field until you're **Compelled** or return through a spirit well.
- **MANIFEST:** Take **1 drain** to flow through the electroplasmic pathways of the ghost field to instantaneously travel to one of the following: *anywhere within 100 paces—the closest spirit well (which may or may not be geographically close in the physical world)—any place you knew intimately in life.*
- **POLTERGEIST:** Take **1 drain** to strongly interact with the physical world for a few minutes (as if you had a normal body). Take **1 drain** for each extra feature: *The effect persists for a few hours—you project telekinetic force equal in strength to a small gang—you channel damaging electroplasmic energy all around you—you emit horrifying sounds and chilling fog to terrify those around you.*

STRANGER

A new playbook for people from the other living world.

Core natures: Curiosity & Secrecy.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

- **FRACTURED:** You have traveled through a **fracture**: an unstable portal from another world. Add an action dot for your background and one for your heritage (as usual). Then distribute four dots among your actions (max rating 2). Depending on the nature of the other world and your past (determined by you and the GM), choose one of the following:
 - ☐ *You know how to handle yourself.* You gain **BATTLEBORN** or **BODYGUARD** from the **Cutter**.
 - ☐ *You have endured great suffering.* You gain **TOUGH AS NAILS** from the **Hound**.
 - ☐ *You are driven to uncover the truth of what's happened to you.* You gain **ANALYST** from the **Leech**.
 - ☐ *The fracture changed you.* You gain **GHOST VEIL** from the **Lurk**.
 - ☐ *You blend in.* You have acquired clothes and accessories to pass as a local and can suppress any accent or unusual idioms. You gain **SUBTERFUGE** from the **Slide**.
 - ☐ *You are familiar with the occult and supernatural.* You gain **GHOST MIND** or **IRON WILL** from the **Whisper**.
 - ☐ *You're specially trained.* Add 1 dot to an action (max rating 3), -OR- gain **ALCHEMIST**, **ARTIFICER**, or **PHYSICKER** from the **Leech**.
- **Assimilated:** Switch to a new playbook and its xp triggers, to reflect your new life in this world. You keep your current action ratings (don't add the starting playbook dots) and special abilities.
- **VETERAN:** Choose a special ability from another source. You can take this special ability more than once.

UNCERTAIN FRIENDS

"Arden," a Stranger

Tessa, an Ink Rake

Anson, a Spark Runner

Bull, a Rail Jack

Hopper, a drugged Seer

STRANGER ITEMS

☐ A Strange Weapon

☐ A Strange Tool or Item

Strange Luxury Item

Strange Clothes

Strange Documents

VAMPIRE

Your vice is **life essence**, consumed from a living human. Whenever you feed on life essence (whether as a downtime activity or an action in play), you indulge your vice. If you overindulge, roll a reaction from the following list. Also, when you feed, fill your healing clock. This is the only way you can heal. *How do you feed? What telltale sign do you leave on your victims?*

VAMPIRE OVERINDULGENCE REACTIONS

- 6 Deepest Thirst:** You don't stop. Your victim suffers fatal harm.
- 4/5 Kin to the Beast:** Your victim is seized with an intense compulsion to feed on living human blood until they next sleep.
- 1-3 Accursed:** You are repelled by living things until your next downtime (you may **push yourself** to overcome this for a scene).

MODIFIED TRAITS

- **UNDEAD:** You are a spirit that animates an undead body. Your trauma is maxed out. Choose four trauma conditions from your playbook that reflect your vampiric nature. You have more Stress boxes (12). Arcane attacks are **potent** against you. If you suffer fatal harm or further trauma, you survive, but you're overwhelmed. While overwhelmed, you are acutely vulnerable—arcane harm can destroy you utterly. To recover from this state, you must feed (and you automatically overindulge).
- **ARCANE SENSES** (formerly **ARCANE SIGHT**): You can see in pitch darkness and can concentrate to hear heartbeats from far away. Spend **1 Stress** to activate an additional benefit for up to one hour: *"hear" a subject's true thoughts or feelings—see through solid matter—perceive the trails left through the ghost field by spirits: living, ghostly, or undead.*
- **TERRIBLE POWER:** Your undead body is especially robust—when you suffer physical harm, reduce its severity by one level. You are always **NOT TO BE TRIFLED WITH** (as per the Cutter ability) without pushing yourself. You may **push yourself** to further increase your scale and physical power.
- **SINISTER GUILF:** During **downtime**, you get two additional free downtime activities.

CREWS

- **Training Upgrades:** You have a veteran **instructor** (Quality rating 3) in that area of expertise, without the need to **Acquire** one. **Mastery** gives you a Quality 4 instructor (and unlocks rating 4 actions). When you advance with one of these instructors, **mark crew xp**.
- **Vaults** are bigger: the first holds 8 coin, the second holds 12.
- **HARDCASE (Prison Claim):** Your reputation as a tough inmate gives your crew respect in the underworld. Reduce the cost of each crew upgrade by 1 coin.
- **INFORMANTS:** You get **+1 tick** on your long-term project clock when you work on an investigation during downtime.
- **PATRON:** You have a benefactor that helps your crew in downtime by reducing one crew **upgrade** cost by 2 -OR- reducing your **Heat** by 2. *Who is your patron? Why do they help you?*
- **WAREHOUSES (Claim):** The crew gains an additional **Acquire** activity each downtime.

ASSASSINS

- **CROW'S VEIL:** Use a **downtime activity** and spend **2 coin** to perform this occult ritual to consecrate a member of the crew. Until their next downtime, any killings they commit will be hidden from the notice of the deathseeker crows. *If there are no witnesses, these killings don't add extra Heat to the crew.*
- **EMBERDEATH:** When you perform the **CROW'S VEIL** ritual, you may spend **+4 coin** on rare arcane materials to create an empowered weapon that causes a named victim and their spirit to disintegrate in a shower of sparking embers at the time of death. This empowerment lasts until your next downtime.
- **NO TRACES:** When you take Heat in downtime, reduce the total by 1. When you end downtime with **zero Heat**, take **+1 Rep**.

BRAVOS

- **BLOOD BROTHERS:** When you fight alongside your cohorts in combat, they throw themselves wildly into the fray. Any PC in the battle may reduce harm they suffer by marking it on the cohort instead. Your cohorts get the Thugs type for free.

CULT

- **ANOINTED:** Choose a type of supernatural being: ghost, vampire, or demon—you now bear a ritual tattoo of warding against those beings. When you suffer harm from a creature of that type, reduce its level by one.
- **BOUND IN DARKNESS:** When you begin a score, each PC that has not lost favor with your deity gains **1 Edge**. You may transfer **Edge** to another cult member without needing to take any action to help them. By taking **1 Stress**, your whispered message is heard by every cult member.
- **CONVICTION:** Each cult member gains an additional **vice**: *Worship*. When you indulge this vice and bring a pleasing sacrifice, you can't overindulge and your deity grants you **1 Edge**.

HAWKERS

- **HIGH SOCIETY:** It's all about who you know. During downtime, name a member of the city's elite: If they have a positive opinion of you, take **-1 Heat**. If not, ask the GM: *Who are they connected to, and what's the nature of the relationship? What scandal, rumor, meeting, or liaison do they wish we didn't know about? Is there a way for us to profit from them?*

SHADOWS

- **PACK RATS:** Your lair is a jumble of stolen goods. Once per downtime, **Acquire** an item with Quality equal to your Tier+1 without spending coin or using a downtime activity.
- **SLIPPERY:** Your effective Wanted Level is one less than its actual value (and may go up to 5). When you suffer an entanglement, reduce any coin, Heat, or Rep cost you pay by one.
- **SYNCHRONIZED:** When you execute a coordinated maneuver as a team, any 6s rolled by any team member can be freely distributed to teammates to use on their rolls.

SMUGGLERS

- **ALL HANDS:** During downtime, one of your cohorts may perform an additional downtime activity to **Acquire** or **Work**.
- **REAVEERS:** When you go into conflict aboard a vehicle, you add **+1 Quality** to the vehicle's damage and speed. The vehicle also gains **+1 armor** to represent skillful maneuvering.

DESIGNER'S NOTES

INNOVATIONS

I like to introduce industrial age innovations in my own home games, so I wanted to include some of that here as a reminder that Dorskvol isn't static—there's always some new (and probably dangerous) prototype or product rolling out of a factory somewhere.

Also, the increasingly unstable Imperium, being threatened from within and without, turns to more experimental solutions and strange technology to try to keep its power, which of course will end up in the hands of nefarious scoundrels eventually.

HARM

In watching a lot of *Blades* actual play videos, I noticed that some players and GMs forget to apply harm penalties. I added a house rule to my own games for the end-of-session xp calculation, including harm alongside trauma as a way to gain xp if it caused problems for the PC. This module expands on that idea so harm is more centered in the fiction and players are rewarded when it comes into play.

TRAUMA

Some groups find trauma too punishing, especially if they misinterpret the rule and knock a character out of the whole score when they suffer trauma (rather than just the present situation). This module addresses that issue, and also adds the possibility of recovery—something I've done in my own home games (and seen other GMs do, too).

LOAD

Sometimes in play, it strains credulity when a scoundrel is suddenly wearing full armor and hauling a demolitions kit, out of nowhere. The concept of Conspicuous and Discreet load options came about as a result.

ADVANCEMENT

Some groups advance more quickly than they want to for a long-running series. I made this module to slow the rate of advancement quite a bit, so characters take longer to reach the higher action and attribute ratings. This integrates well with the other modules that increase xp gain a bit (like harm and trauma). Players can enjoy a steady progress of xp rewards without advancing too quickly.

Of course, you can change the size of the advancement clocks to tweak things even more. Try 4-segment or 8-segment clocks if you want to customize the rate of advancement for your series.

DOWNTIME

I modified downtime activities to be diceless so they're more reliable—I've seen disappointed faces from players when downtime rolls didn't go well and they felt like opportunities were wasted.

Payoff is increased, and there are more ways to spend coin. This is a personal preference, really—I tend to give a little more coin than some other *Blades* GMs, and I like the effect on play when the crew has more cash to throw around, so I included it in the system here.

Tying the gain of Rep to gaining Heat means that there's an incentive to make things a bit noisy and chaotic. People hear about your crew, and your Rep grows—at the cost of attention from the authorities.

Recovery is modified to be a bit less punishing than in standard *Blades*, which is a common complaint I hear about the original mechanic. In this module, you can more reliably heal fully in one downtime cycle, assuming you have the funds to pay for it.

Training in this system is a complete 180 from how it works in standard *Blades*. Rather than earning xp when you train, now you have to spend a downtime activity just to *spend* xp! This change comes from several *Blades* games of my own (as well as watching other people play) in which some players didn't really click with the growth and change of their characters. They wanted something more rooted in the fiction. So I created this system to give players a chance to show how their scoundrels learned new things and who was teaching them. Also, by removing training as a source of xp, character advancement is slowed down a little bit, which can be good in long-running games.

ACTION

Lots of stuff changed in the action system as I've tweaked and modified it for my *Blades* games over the years. Some rough edges are smoothed down (in my opinion, anyway) to speed up play and reduce frustrating interactions. I hope they'll help out in your games, too.

THE THREAT ROLL

The general design of the threat roll is a refinement of the resistance roll, of course. Rather than getting bogged down in rolls to “see if you can do it,” this system focuses the tension on *avoiding bad outcomes*. The competent actions of the scoundrels are assumed by the system. They're often in a lot of danger, but not because they *can't* do something—but because they *can*! In order for “failure” to even be a thing, the GM has to choose it as a special case—not a normal part of the dice mechanic.

This modification was designed to emulate how I like to run *Blades* these days—emphasizing the dangers the scoundrels face and their consequences, rather than the success or failure of actions.

However, as noted on **page 99**, if you want the threat roll to feel more like the original action roll, it's okay to add the threat of failure most of the time. The hard choice between success and avoiding danger on a mixed roll is something some groups really enjoy.

The main benefit of this change is that it requires the GM to describe the potential bad outcome *before* the roll. Because of this, the GM doesn't have to invent a complication after the fact, so they're less “on the spot.”

Some players get fatigued when new problems are introduced each time they get a 4/5. With this module, each roll resolves the threats at hand. The action of the game moves forward, from one threat to the next, instead of spiraling from one mixed roll.

This system also smooths out the position and effect conversation by assuming a risky/standard position and effect for almost every action.

Since the desperate roll is much harder, the group can still be challenged by really tough opponents, even in the late game. Hitting the “hard six” on a roll is never guaranteed.

I want to acknowledge that the concept of rolling dice and assigning a result to each possible outcome appears in *Otherkind* by Vincent Baker and *Psi*Run* by Meguey Baker. It's also in my games *Ghost.Echo* and *Danger Patrol*, but I'm pretty sure Vincent and Meg came up with it first.

CONTROLLED POSITION

Some GMs call for too many rolls, especially for “routine” or low-stakes actions, and then struggle to come up with consequences on the fly. This is an issue with a lot of games! The dreaded no-stakes “perception check” has plagued the hobby forever.

I tweaked the controlled position in this system so it's obvious that characters can sometimes “just do it” without bringing consequences and randomness into the mix. When they manage those rare controlled circumstances, highlight the scoundrels' skills! Give them the victories they deserve. A new threat will loom up soon enough.

DEVIL'S BARGAIN

I was talking to Allison about *Blades* one day, and this phrase popped out: “It's like the whole game starts with a Devil's Bargain: You want to advance the fortunes of your crew in the underworld of Daskvol? There's a chance you can do it, but you'll have to risk Stress, trauma, harm, and all manner of consequences. Do we have a deal?” This led to me noticing that a lot of moments in game play look like diceless Devil's Bargains—so why not formalize that into the action resolution process?

In practice, “pay a cost and you do it” smooths over situations that can get bogged down when dice rolls, consequences, and resistance come into play. Sometimes it's nice to just say, “How about you take 1 Stress and do it?” then move on to the stuff everyone is more interested in.

From a certain point of view, this is how flashbacks work already—a mini Devil's Bargain, paying Stress to get stuff done in the past.

A NOTE ABOUT RESOLVE THREATS

Few roleplaying games have mechanics that directly impact a character's inner thoughts, feelings, and motivations, so some players might be averse to rolling dice about those things. If that's the case, you can back off from threats of that nature—using **RESOLVE** only when they need it to push themselves. However, if a player is up for it, it can be a lot of fun to leave some aspects of the character's persona and behavior up to the outcomes of a threat roll.

A player might roll to steel their nerve to commit murder, or to see if they hesitate in the face of overwhelming odds, or to find out if they can keep their impulses in check when they're provoked.

After all, in the dangerous underworld of Daskvol—a life of close calls, sudden shocks, powerful desires, and emotional struggles—it's sometimes the scoundrel with the greater **RESOLVE** that makes it through.

PUSH YOURSELF

I've seen some players be disappointed when they spent 2 Stress to push and then all their dice rolled high. This mechanic was changed to take place after the roll, once the player knows how well it went. It's never "wasted"—you only push when you need to because of a bad roll or to activate a special ability.

And since it's after the threat roll, combining this mechanic with resistance just made sense. Also, by limiting the range of possible Stress costs, characters can be a bit more daring. No more flubbed resistance rolls that suddenly cost you 5 Stress out of nowhere.

GATHERING INFORMATION

I've seen some game groups get confused by a separate "gather info" roll in the game, with a tendency to treat it as an outlier to the rest of play. In practice, "gather info" actions can easily flow with the rest of the game, and don't need a separate type of roll, so I rewrote the instructions to illustrate how to integrate the question-and-answer process more smoothly into play.

This led to the revision of several special abilities to include a list of useful questions for players to ask in certain situations. This construction will be familiar to anyone who's played *Apocalypse World*, which is what inspired those ability changes.

TEAMWORK

Like gathering information, in practice at the table, I usually see teamwork that's organic and flows with the systems of play, which can cause a bit of a stumble when suddenly a specific teamwork mechanic needs to be referenced.

With this revision, I tried to better capture what I see groups doing in play, integrating the general systems of Devil's Bargains and threat rolls into their teamwork actions in a way that's easily adaptable to the most common kinds of group maneuvers.

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